Oversteer My Heart!

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Oversteer My Heart!

by Lunaeryi

Summary

Mydei gave up a guaranteed corporate empire to pursue racing, which means his life now consists of blistering speeds, unreasonable expectations, and pretending he's completely normal about the figure skater he may or may not have admired for years.

Phainon just came back from hiatus, has a dangerous lack of subtlety, and a habit of flirting without realizing he's flirting—especially with the very attractive F1 driver who keeps making deeply specific comments about his past performances.

"Your footwork in Shanghai was clean, too."

Phainon turns toward him fully this time, eyebrows lifting as he repeats the word.

"Shanghai," he says. "That was… a while ago."

Unfortunately for Mydei, the only person he *won't* have to worry about teasing him is Phainon.

Notes

Hellooooo finally finished this!! Quick mention but this was inspired with more of a "Flame Reaver" Phainon in mind so do as you will with that :)

Chapter 1: 14A

Chapter Summary

> Mydei survives Spain, narrowly avoids murder by luggage, accidentally almost outs himself as a lifelong Phainon fangirl, and somehow ends up in the same row on a plane with the man himself.
>
> He blames Cipher and Hephaestion wholeheartedly for this.

Chapter Notes

> the majority of this was already written, so this is gonna have relatively consistent updates? I'm just HEAVILY revising everything because I want to add more to some scenes (cause originally this was meant to be a one shot but spiraled) I rushed, and I want better dialogue so yeah.
>
> Hope y'all enjoy reading <3333

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mydei almost dies at least six times before lunch.

This is not a complaint. This is simply how racing works.

At the Circuit de Barcelona-Catalunya, the sun hangs low and smug, baking the asphalt until it radiates heat like it's holding a grudge. The track shimmers. The grandstands ripple. Somewhere in the distance, a flag waves with the enthusiasm of a tired fan who has been here since dawn and refuses to leave without compensation.

Inside Car 27, Mydei is cooking alive.

Spain has decided that race day is an appropriate time to turn the weather into a personal attack. His fireproof suit traps heat with surgical efficiency, sweat pooling along his spine, his gloves damp enough to be annoying but

not dangerous. The visor fogs every time he exhales, as if the car itself is offended by human respiration.

At 312 kilometers per hour, this is still the least of his problems.

The world narrows.

Not into silence, because cars never shut up, but into something precise. The engine’s vibration hums through his bones. The steering wheel chatters in his hands. The tires scream their opinions at every corner entry, dramatic and unhelpful as always. Every sensation stacks on top of the other until thought becomes instinct and instinct becomes command.

Mydei thrives here.

“Front left degradation increasing,” Hephaestion says in his ear, voice steady in the way of a man who has already accepted that stress is a lifestyle choice. “Sixty-eight percent. ERS thirty-eight. Delta plus four-tenths to Morales.”

Santiago Morales.

Spain’s darling menace. Local hero. Late-braking menace with a smile so charming it should be illegal. The crowd adores him with the kind of loyalty usually reserved for football clubs and childhood pets.

They are being very loud about it.

Mydei flicks the wheel slightly, adjusting brake bias with the casual confidence of someone rearranging furniture he owns.

“I can take him.”

A pause.

Hephaestion exhales like a man counting to ten in multiple languages. “Box this lap unless you’re going for it at Turn Ten.”

“That sounds like permission.”

“It absolutely is not.”

“And yet.”

“And Perdikkas will personally superglue you to the simulator if you injure your shoulder again.”

Mydei considers this, accelerating through Turn Seven with elegant aggression. “He said that last time too.”

“That was also a direct quote. I edited out profanity.”

“…I appreciate your restraint.”

The garage exists somewhere far away, vibrating with stress and caffeine. Leonnius is pacing, no doubt. Ptolemy is probably writing numbers that mean something only to him. Perdikkas is preparing to commit an act of violence against the concept of recklessness.

They cannot talk to Mydei.

Race rules.

This is the quiet part.

This is his favorite part.

He charges toward Campsa, Turn Nine, a corner infamous for asking drivers deeply personal questions about their life choices, to which Mydei answers by taking it flat.

The car howls. The tires protest. G-force pins him back like an accusation.

He exhales, controlled, practiced. The visor fogs for half a second.

Annoying.

“DRS on exit. ERS deploy ready,” Hephaestion says, focused.

“I know.”

“You always know. I still have to say it.”

“Occupational hazard.”

“Please sound less arrogant while driving.”

“No promises.”

Ahead, Morales defends the racing line like it’s family property. His rear tires twitch under braking, old rubber begging for mercy. Mydei clocks it instantly, brain doing math faster than conscious thought.

Turn Ten approaches.

Heavy braking. Narrow entry. Glory or embarrassment.

Morales brakes early.

Mydei does not.

He opens DRS and the car lunges forward like it’s been insulted, speed surging, wind clawing at him. He feints outside, watches Morales commit, and then slices inside with surgical cruelty.

Late braking. Trail braking. The front tires flirt with disaster.

Mydei corrects with a tiny movement, elegant and instinctive, the kind of motion that looks effortless because it has been practiced to death.

The crowd erupts.

Morales gives him space. Barely. Enough.

Mydei slips through, slotting ahead like he belongs there.

Because he does.

He feels it then, sharp and bright in his chest, a flash of something dangerously close to joy.

Beautiful.

Hephaestion explodes in his ear. “YES—YES—THAT’S IT! THAT’S HOW YOU SEND A MAN INTO RETIREMENT WITHOUT TOUCHING HIM!”

Something crashes in the garage. A clipboard dies. Ptolemy mourns.

The rest of the race blurs into discipline and control. Tire management. Clean exits. Ignoring half of Hephaestion’s increasingly frantic reminders. Accepting a track limits warning with a hum and a promise to behave that means nothing.

When the checkered flag waves, Mydei crosses the line with a gap wide enough to feel intentional.

P1.

Everyone roars.

His heart stays steady.

“All clear,” Hephaestion says, voice wrecked with relief.

“Copy,” Mydei replies.

Inside the helmet, he smiles.

Somewhere in Barcelona, a barista is about to experience the single greatest iced coffee order of their career.

The first coherent thought Mydei has after crossing the finish line—after the crowd detonates into noise, after the fireworks bloom, after Hephaestion screams something over the radio that might technically qualify as a religious experience—is not noble.

It is not reflective, nor particularly patriotic.

It is not, in any way, befitting a race winner.

If they spray champagne directly into my eyes again, I will simply leave this plane of existence.

He lets the car roll into the cooldown lap, easing his grip on the wheel as adrenaline drains out of him in a warm, buzzing haze. His pulse still beats against the carbon fiber grips, steady and stubborn, like it refuses to accept that the danger part is over. Heat clings to him aggressively. Barcelona has been hot all weekend, but now it feels personal, like the city itself is trying to finish him off where the track failed.

Inside the suit, sweat has given up on subtlety. The fabric sticks. His gloves are soaked. His fireproof balaclava has reached a state best described as *emotionally damp.*

He exhales, slow and controlled, fogging the visor for half a second.

Annoying. Seriously annoying.

“You realize,” Hephaestion says in his ear, voice hoarse and vibrating with adrenaline he absolutely did not burn off himself, “that you just ruined at least three Spanish childhoods.”

“I thought I was being nice,” Mydei replies. “I left him room.”

“Uh-huh, *sure*.”

The radio crackles with overlapping voices now. Someone cheers. Someone else laughs a little hysterically. Ptolemy, unmistakable even through static, announces that he knew Turn Ten was the move and that he has the data to prove it, which no one asked for.

Hephaestion tries—and fails—to reassert radio discipline. “Alright, alright, deep breaths, everyone. Mydei, all clear. Bring it home.”

“I am literally already done.”

“Yes, and yet I still don’t trust you.”

Mydei hums in acknowledgment as he guides the car toward the pit lane. The crowd noise swells again, pressing in through the helmet, through the cockpit, through the bones in his skull. Flags wave. His name ripples across the grandstands, distorted and echoing, a thousand strangers shouting in unison.

He does not wave back.

That part comes later.

Parc fermé hits him like a wall of movement. Engineers swarm the car the moment it stops, practiced and precise, hands already on the chassis before the tires have finished whining. One mechanic taps the halo twice—quick, affectionate, ritualistic—and another gives him a thumbs-up that somehow manages to look deeply relieved.

Cameras descend immediately. Lenses everywhere. Red lights blinking like insects.

A marshal gestures for engine off.

Mydei kills the car, silence rushing in so suddenly it feels unreal. He removes the steering wheel with careful hands, ignoring the faint tremor in his fingers. Leftover electricity. It happens every time. He almost drops it anyway.

“Please don’t break anything important,” Leonnius calls from somewhere to his left, appearing out of the chaos as if he’s been stress-sprinting for the last two hours. “We’re already over budget on replacement parts.”

“I caught it,” Mydei mutters. “Have some faith.”

Leonnius snorts. “I had faith once. It didn’t survive Turn Seven.”

Mydei climbs out of the cockpit, boots hitting concrete, and the sound slams into him all at once. The crowd roars louder now that he’s visible, a physical thing that presses against his chest. Someone near the fence is

waving a massive cutout of his face that looks like it was printed from a screenshot taken during turbulence.

He removes his gloves, folding them neatly despite the shake in his hands. He’s learned how to do that without thinking. He’s learned what cameras notice.

Perdikkas materializes at his side like an omen.

He drapes something over Mydei’s shoulders that technically qualifies as a flannel but is, in practice, the size of a ceremonial banner.

“Drink,” Perdikkas says, already shoving a bottle into his hands. “You underhydrated on lap forty-three.”

“I was busy,” Mydei replies, taking a sip anyway.

“You were reckless.”

“I was efficient.”

“You were one corner away from me committing a crime.”

Perdikkas leans in slightly, voice dropping. “If you do that again without telling me first, I will replace your steering wheel with a conscience.”

Mydei swallows another mouthful. “Noted.”

Peucesta slips in on his other side without announcing himself, like a shadow. He smells faintly of expensive lotion and impending press releases. A tablet rests in his hands, its screen a mosaic of timing sheets, sponsor notifications, and photos Mydei would prefer never see daylight.

“Smile,” Peucesta murmurs, adjusting the drape of the flannel with two precise fingers. “Just once.”

“I am smiling on the inside.”

“That does not monetize.”

Mydei sighs.

Peucesta tilts his head, eyes flicking briefly toward one of the cameras, then back to Mydei. “Your father is watching.”

That does it.

Mydei lifts the corners of his mouth into something small, controlled, and perfectly acceptable. It is not joy. It is not triumph. It is the kind of smile that says *yes, I am alive, yes, I did the thing, please do not ask more of me.*

The cameras eat it up.

Peucesta nods once, satisfied.

“Good,” he says. “We’ll go viral.”

Somewhere behind them, Hephaestion finally breaks free of the garage and barrels toward him, headset crooked, eyes bright. “That pass,” he says breathlessly, hands flying, “that was—my god, that was *art*.”

Mydei inclines his head. “I aim to please.”

“Don’t,” Perdikkas says flatly. “It encourages him.”

Mydei’s gaze drifts back toward the track. His heart has finally settled. The noise fades into something distant and manageable.

He stands there, wrapped in fabric and voices and expectation, grounded and steady in the aftermath.

Winner.

And somehow, already thinking about the next one.

The walk to the weigh-in station is less a walk and more a controlled evacuation.

The FIA corridor funnels him forward while reporters stack up behind the barrier like birds on a wire, voices flying over one another with absolutely no regard for acoustics or human survival.

“MYDEI—HOW DID YOU FIND THE MOVE ON MORALES?”
”IS THIS YOUR STRONGEST SEASON YET?”
“ARE THE RUMORS ABOUT YOUR FAMILY TRUE?”
“MYDEI—GREECE IS VERY PROUD—”

That last one is shouted with particular fervor, the accent unmistakable, and it cuts cleanly through the noise.

Mydei does not look over, but he does grimace internally.

He keeps his gaze forward, posture relaxed, stride unhurried, like this is not his personal gauntlet. He has learned, over time, that acknowledgment is blood in the water.

That does not stop the crowd.

Kids lean over the barriers, waving flags too big for their arms. One boy trips over his own sneakers trying to keep up, only to be hauled upright by a mortified parent. Someone has brought a megaphone and is using it exclusively to yell “MYDEI” at wildly inappropriate intervals.

A handmade sign bobs into view:

DRIVE FAST BUT SAFELY
PLEASE
MY MOM IS WORRIED

Mydei breaks.

Just a little.

He glances over and gives the kid a real smile, brief but unmistakable, lifting two fingers in acknowledgment. The boy loses his mind completely, jumping so hard his sign folds in half.

Peucesta clocks it from behind him and, mercifully, says nothing.

Inside the tent, the noise changes shape rather than volume.

Leonnius is mid-sentence, arms flailing.

“—I’m telling you, centimeters,” Leonnius says, hands slicing the air. “Centimeters from the apex cone. I saw my career flash before my eyes. Do you understand how stupid that was? How beautiful? How—”

“Almost isn’t clipping,” Mydei interrupts calmly, stepping onto the scale.

Perdikkas makes a noise of deep, personal offense. “Almost gives me paperwork. Clip it next time and at least make it worth the medical report.”

“You would enjoy that far too much,” Mydei replies.

“I enjoy job security,” Perdikkas snaps. “You threaten it weekly.”

Hephaestion slips in close once the officials are distracted, bumping Mydei’s arm with his own. It’s small, deliberate, grounding.

“Good job, Mydeimos,” he says, voice low and worn in the way of someone who has spent two hours clenching every muscle he owns. “Textbook disorder.”

Mydei hums. “You sound relieved.”

“I am. I aged five years.”

Everything collapses into motion after that.

The weigh-in. Helmet off. A mechanic nearly tackles him in a hug. Someone claps him on the back hard enough to make a point about posture. Ptolemy appears with red eyes and insists it’s pollen season despite being indoors. Peucesta replaces one water bottle with another like a magician with a hydration obsession.

By the time it’s over, Mydei feels wrung out but upright, which he considers a success.

The podium wait is mercifully uneventful.

No champagne ambush. His vision remains intact.

Morales nearly dislocates his shoulder in a congratulatory hug and laughs like he’s still halfway in the car. “You’re insane,” he says, delighted.

“You defended beautifully,” Mydei replies, sincere.

Then comes the interview pen.

The lights are brutal. The microphones multiply. Peucesta takes up position just behind his right shoulder, tablet in hand, expression neutral enough to be legally classified as a weapon.

The questions come in waves.

The British want tire degradation and sector deltas.

The Spanish want Morales—how hard he pushed, whether it surprised him, whether respect still stands.

The French start doing math out loud, already trying to crown a champion with three races left.

Then the cadence shifts.

The Greek journalists however, go straight for the jugular.

“Was your father present at today’s race?”
“Would you care to comment on Castrum Kremnos’ most recent endorsement?”
”Do you see yourself returning to Greece following retirement—or sooner?”
”You’re young,” one of them adds, politely ruthless, “but there are conversations about succession. Is there any truth to that?”

The word *succession* lands with weight.

Mydei doesn’t flinch.

He answers the way he’s been trained to: clean lines, no excess. His focus is on the race. He’s grateful for the support. He’s proud of his heritage. He’s taking things one season at a time.

He gives them nothing they can quote out of context, nothing that can be underlined in red.

One voice presses closer anyway, earnest with intent.

“Is it true you’ve avoided your father’s last three calls?”

The mood sours noticeably.

Hephaestion steps forward smoothly, badge visible, tone crisp and final. “That’s enough. Driver to debrief.”

Peucesta is already there, guiding Mydei away with a hand at his elbow before anyone can pretend the question was harmless.

The noise dulls behind them.

Only then does Mydei let out a slow breath, controlled, like easing off the throttle at the end of a long straight.

“Welcome back to reality,” Peucesta says, scrolling through his tablet. “Podium, television studio, three sponsor photos. Then you’re briefly free.”

“Briefly?”

“Twenty minutes. Thirty if Perdikkas is otherwise occupied.”

“That’s not the freedom I was envisioning,” Mydei says. “Conditional release seems more like it...”

Peucesta allows himself the faintest hint of a smile. “For someone who just dominated a race, you complain a remarkable amount.”

“It keeps me grounded.”

“I wish you’d picked meditation.”

Mydei glances back toward the paddock—the flags still snapping in the heat, the hum of generators, the mechanics laughing over loose cables and empty cups.

He likes this part. The noise. The chaos. The clarity of being wanted for exactly one thing, and doing it well.

He straightens his clothes, wipes champagne from his cheek, and follows Peucesta onward.

The day isn’t done yet.

But for now, it feels—quietly, stubbornly—good to still be here.

Mydei rubs at his cheek one last time, finally dislodging the stubborn fleck of glitter that’s been haunting him since the podium. It sticks briefly to his thumb like it’s considering making a comeback, then he wipes it on the inside of his sleeve and calls it a day.

Around him, the team disperses in the familiar, post-race scramble. Someone’s arguing with a crate that refuses to roll straight. Someone else is power-walking while chugging coffee that smells aggressive enough to qualify as a biohazard. A pair of mechanics are laughing too loudly about something that definitely involved a near-miss and a lot of swearing.

Normal. Comfortingly so.

He falls into step beside Peucesta, who’s walking with the unhurried confidence of a man who knows exactly where he’s going and exactly how annoyed he’ll be when he gets there. His tablet is already out, thumb

scrolling, expression caught somewhere between focused and quietly judgmental.

Without looking up, Peucesta says, “If anyone asks about your father today, blink twice and I’ll have them escorted into the sun.”

Mydei snorts. “Is that in the official media protocol?”

“It’s a footnote,” Peucesta replies. “Right under ‘smile politely’ and ‘do not commit international incidents.’”

“That feels like a high bar.”

“You clear it inconsistently. It comes with your background.”

The corner of Mydei’s mouth ticks up. Peucesta never tries to be funny, which somehow makes it worse—or better, depending on who you ask. Perdikkas once claimed it was a choice. Peucesta denied this with great offense and absolutely no conviction.

They pass Hephaestion, who’s leaned against a stack of tires and talking with Leonnius in low, animated tones.

“I’m just saying,” Leonnius insists, hands moving like he’s diagramming a crime scene, “that if he keeps doing that, I’m going to start aging in dog years.”

“You age in dog years already,” Hephaestion says mildly. “Might as well already be in your 80s.”

Leonnius points at Mydei as he passes. “You hear that? Zero support. None.”

“You’re still here,” Mydei says. “That means I did my job.”

“Barely,” Leonnius replies, but he’s grinning, eyes bright in that way that means he’s already replaying the race in his head, reliving every stupid, brilliant second.

The path toward the press pen opens up ahead, wider than the rest of the paddock, and the noise shifts again—voices rising, cameras clicking, the unmistakable hum of attention. It’s always louder there, which unfortunately never fails to give him a headache.

Peucesta slows half a step, scanning ahead.

“There’s a crowd forming,” he says. “Not the usual configuration.”

Mydei glances up. Beyond the media cluster, there’s a different knot of people—less frantic, more deliberate. Suits mixed with streetwear. Federation badges held just a little higher. A ripple of excitement that feels curated.

“Huh,” Mydei says. “Someone brought something with them.”

“Yes,” Peucesta agrees. “And unfortunately, it’s contagious.”

They walk a little farther. The squeals crest, then settle into a buzz of recognition.

Peucesta tilts his tablet, checks something, then sighs through his nose.

“Well,” he says. “That explains it.”

Mydei raises a brow. “You’re going to make me ask, aren’t you.”

“I am,” Peucesta says, deadpan. “Because if I volunteer this information, you’ll stop walking.”

“Now I’m definitely stopping.”

“Aglaea’s here.”

That does it.

Mydei actually slows, turning his head this time. “Aglaea as in—”

“As in that one,” Peucesta says. “And yes, she brought half her orbit with her.”

Mydei exhales, something between a laugh and a resigned sound of acceptance. “At a race weekend.”

“She doesn’t do coincidences,” Peucesta replies. “If she’s here, it’s because she wants to be seen being here.”

That tracks.

Aglaea has always been like that. The kind of woman who never raises her voice because she doesn’t need to. Mydei’s met her exactly twice before in an official setting, both times in rooms where everyone else was pretending not to be nervous.

He glances toward the cluster again, more curious than wary now.

“Should I say hello?” he asks.

Peucesta gives him a look. “You’re a race winner walking through her field of vision. If you don’t, she’ll remember.”

“Is that a threat?”

“It’s an observation.”

They angle slightly, skirting the edge of the gathering. Aglaea stands near the center, engaged in conversation with a Federation representative who looks like he’s concentrating very hard on not sweating through his suit. She’s dressed impeccably, but not stiffly—tailored and fashionable as always. There’s a mellow look to her expression that doesn’t quite reach her eyes, paired with the kind of polite humor that seems to land with surgical precision.

She laughs at something the rep says, brief and genuine, then corrects him immediately after. The rep nods like he’s been blessed.

Mydei huffs softly. “She hasn’t changed.”

“She has,” Peucesta says. “She just got better at hiding it.”

That’s when Peucesta’s gaze flicks sideways, sharp and assessing.

“…Huh.”

Mydei follows it automatically.

At first, nothing stands out. Just another figure on the fringe of the group, half a step back from Aglaea, posture loose, hands tucked casually into the pockets of a hoodie that looks wildly out of place among the suits.

He almost looks like he wandered in by accident.

Almost.

Mydei keeps walking, brain already categorizing and discarding. Some consultant, maybe. A friend. A relative. Someone waiting their turn.

Then the man shifts.

Just slightly. Weight rolling from one foot to the other. Head tilting as he listens.

The light catches his face.

A flash of white at the temple. Not dyed—natural, threaded through his messy hair. A familiar line along his cheekbone, a scar Mydei has seen before, though never like this. Not in person. Not close enough to count the years in it.

Mydei’s steps slow.

He doesn’t stop outright. That would draw attention. But something inside him does—a quiet, internal halt, like a handbrake pulled too hard.

The atmosphere feels different here. Cooler. Sharp with something clean and almost medicinal, a scent that tugs at a memory he can’t immediately place.

The man looks up.

Not at Mydei. Not yet.

But the angle of his face, the set of his shoulders, the way he occupies space without claiming it—

Mydei's stomach drops.

Recognition doesn't arrive as a thought. It arrives as a certainty.

He knows that silhouette.

His breath catches, shallow and involuntary, and for the first time all day, the noise of the paddock fades into something distant and indistinct.

Aglaea turns slightly, saying something to the man at her shoulder.

He responds quietly.

The sound of his voice reaches Mydei a second later—low, even, unhurried—and it lands like a physical thing.

Mydei stops.

Fully this time.

Whatever he was about to say to Aglaea evaporates. Whatever plan he had dissolves. All that's left is the undeniable, impossible fact standing a few meters away, wearing a hoodie like this is just another afternoon.

Oh.

Oh.

His pulse spikes, loud in his ears, as the man turns—finally—into full view.

What the hell.

Aglaea finishes her conversation mid-sentence, expression sharpening as new information slots into place. She steps aside with practiced ease, clearing the narrow corridor through the paddock like she's redirecting foot traffic without ever raising her voice.

He passes through the opening she creates.

Mydei's brain supplies a dozen reasonable explanations in rapid succession. Assistant. Consultant. Someone late to something important. Someone who belongs here in a way that has nothing to do with—

Aglaea says his name, casual as breathing.

"—Phainon."

He turns at the sound of it. She angles her phone toward him; he leans in just enough to glance at the screen, shoulder nearly brushing hers. Whatever she's showing him earns a quiet hum of acknowledgment, something that sounds suspiciously like amusement.

He says a few words—too low to catch over the paddock noise—but Aglaea's mouth curves, sharp and fond in equal measure. She taps the screen once, decisive, and pockets the phone.

"All right," she says. "Go."

Phainon nods. Easy. Comfortable. He shifts his weight and steps away from her—

—and starts walking straight toward Mydei.

Oh.

Mydei doesn't move. He tells himself it's because the walkway is crowded, because stepping aside now would be awkward, because he's perfectly capable of behaving like a normal human being.

None of that helps his pulse, which decides this is an excellent moment to start misbehaving.

The hoodie is soft-looking, sleeves pushed up just enough to reveal strong forearms, and Mydei's brain immediately files that away as deeply unhelpful information.

By the time Phainon reaches him, Mydei is acutely aware of everything: the lingering heat under his race suit, the faint thrum of generators, the way his heartbeat seems to have climbed into his throat and refuses to come down.

Phainon slows.

Not stopping at first—just easing his stride, attention sliding sideways as he registers Mydei's presence. Their shoulders nearly brush as he passes, close enough that Mydei catches a clean, cool scent that cuts through the paddock haze.

Then Phainon stops.

It's brief. Barely more than a beat.

His hand comes up, light and sure, settling on Mydei's shoulder like it belongs there. The contact is warm through the fabric, deliberate without being strange. Familiar, somehow, even though they've never met like this.

Phainon looks at him then—really looks. His gaze lingers, curious and bright in a way that feels chosen.

"Congrats," he says. His voice is calm, textured, pitched low enough that it feels like it's meant just for Mydei. "That last lap was beautiful."

The word lands clean and devastating.

Mydei's breath stutters before he can stop it. His heart kicks, hard enough that he's suddenly grateful for the noise around them, for the way the paddock swallows small, human reactions whole.

Beautiful.

He's heard fast. Aggressive. Controlled. Stupidly brave. He's heard worse. He's heard better. But beautiful—

That’s different.

Phainon’s thumb shifts slightly where it rests, a subtle press, as if punctuating the compliment. His mouth curves—not quite a smile, but something close enough to promise one later.

Mydei opens his mouth. His brain offers him nothing useful. Gratitude tangles with surprise, admiration with something warmer and more—*ahem*.

Before he can commit to a sentence, someone calls Phainon’s name from further down the walkway.

Phainon glances over his shoulder, then back at Mydei. The hand on his shoulder lifts, fingers trailing just enough to register as intentional.

“Enjoy the rest of it,” he adds, easy. “You earned it.”

Then he’s gone—already moving, already folding back into the flow of the paddock like this was just another stop along the way.

Mydei stays where he is.

The noise rushes back in around him: carts rattling, voices overlapping, a mechanic laughing too loudly nearby. His heart takes its time catching up, thudding steady and insistent, like it’s trying to get his attention.

Peucesta finds him a few seconds later.

He stops short, eyes narrowing with professional suspicion. “Why do you look like you got run over by your own car?”

Mydei blinks. Once. Twice.

Peucesta leans in, scanning his face. “You’re flushed. That’s new. You don’t flush.”

“I just—” Mydei starts, then stops. He has no idea how to finish that sentence.

Peucesta exhales through his nose, already hooking a hand around Mydei’s arm and steering him back toward the press corridor. “Fantastic. Whatever that was, bottle it and unpack later. We’re on in ten, and you’re drifting.”

“I’m walking,” Mydei protests weakly.

“You’re wandering,” Peucesta corrects. “There’s a difference.”

They round the corner toward the media area. Flashes spark behind the barricades, a wall of sound rising to meet them.

Mydei lets himself be guided, steps falling back into rhythm by habit alone. His mind, however, lingers stubbornly behind—on a quiet voice, a warm hand, and a single word that refuses to leave him alone.

Beautiful.

Yeah.

What a day.

Speaking of days, It should have been an ordinary one.

It tried very hard to be one.

Unfortunately, Phainon exists, and Mydei has learned—through long, empirical suffering—that the universe refuses to treat anything as normal when Phainon is anywhere within a reasonable radius.

The hotel room is dark except for the television, which washes the walls in a low, aquatic blue. Onscreen, a car dives into a corner in slow motion, tires deforming under impossible pressure, sparks ghosting off the curb. The volume is muted. Without sound, it looks less like a broadcast and more like a memory replaying itself without permission.

Mydei sits on the carpet, back against the bed, legs crossed like he forgot how chairs work. His hair is still damp, water trailing lazily down his neck and along his jaw. Every so often he scrubs his bangs back with the heel of

his hand, annoyed in the vague way one gets when the body hasn’t quite caught up with the day yet.

He’s looking for something.

This becomes obvious when he starts shoving an arm under the mattress, muttering at the bed frame like it purposefully offended him.

“Come on,” he mutters to himself, fingers stretching farther than is reasonable. “I know you’re here.”

His hand catches on something stiff and familiar, cardboard scraping against his knuckles. He tugs it free and exhales in quiet triumph.

“Ha!”

The sound is small and deeply embarrassing. He hopes no one ever hears it.

The notebook looks like it survived childhood on drugs alone. The cover is warped, the spine cracked and held together by tape that gave up years ago. Corners curl inward like they’re trying to escape. Pen dents scar the surface where someone once pressed far too hard while thinking far too loudly.

KHAOS.

The title is written in aggressive block letters, each stroke heavy and uneven. Teenager something-year-old Mydei had clearly believed intensity equaled credibility.

He stares at it for a moment, then groans softly.

“I can’t believe I brought you again.”

He always does. Every major race week. He pretends it’s superstition-adjacent coincidence, not a ritual. If anyone from the team ever opened it expecting telemetry or setup notes, they’d be deeply disappointed and probably a little concerned.

When he flips it open, the pages release a smell that feels older than it should be—dust, cheap glue, ink that never quite settled. It’s the scent of late nights and bad printers and a kid who didn’t know when to stop caring.

Inside is a museum of fixation.

Grainy screenshots from skating broadcasts printed off questionable fan sites. Magazine clippings with fonts that aged catastrophically. Diagrams of jump entries covered in arrows and frantic annotations, like he’d been trying to reverse-engineer a miracle.

One page holds a photo of Phainon suspended midair, body so cleanly aligned it borders on insulting. Mydei had drawn a huge arrow pointing at him.

HOW IS THIS POSSIBLE????

He presses a hand over his face.

“Jesus,” he mutters. “Get a grip.”

Another page.

counter-rotation?? how???
blade curve trajectory ≠ humanly feasible???
if i train enough i can land this

The handwriting veers wildly—neat and careful in places, devolving into jagged scrawl where excitement clearly overwhelmed fine motor control. He traces a thumb over the ink, feeling the slight grooves where the pen dug in.

He would rather take Turn Nine flat again than let another person see this.

With a quiet huff, he lets himself fall back onto the bed, notebook balanced against his chest. Pages flutter, then settle. The blue light from the TV softens everything, blurring the edges of the room until it feels less like a hotel and more like a place memory built on purpose.

“You were ridiculous…” he tells his younger self, fond despite himself.

The obsession doesn’t embarrass him. That part feels normal—necessary, even. Every teen has something that grabs them too hard and refuses to let go.

It’s the devotion that makes him wince.

“Khaos,” he says quietly, eyes drifting back to the cover.

The nickname had spread fast back then, born from Phainon’s skating—those violent tempo shifts, the way he snapped direction mid-rotation like the ice was optional. American commentators, predictably, latched onto “Chaos on Ice” because it was easy and loud and fit neatly on a graphic.

Then someone tried to be clever.

“Khaos on Ice,” the commentator had announced on live television, sounding very pleased with himself.

He hadn’t meant the Greek concept at all. He genuinely thought that was how the word was pronounced.

The internet did what it always does. First confusion. Then jokes. Then absolute collapse.

Only later did someone point out that Khaos was, in fact, the primordial void in Greek mythology—which retroactively made the commentator look intentional instead of illiterate.

And because Phainon is Phainon, he leaned into it. Stood at a press conference with that faint, entertained smile and said, “Sure. Khaos works.”

That was that.

The title stuck.

Mydei had liked a different name.

The Deliverer.

It surfaced once, during Junior Worlds, after Phainon salvaged a performance from what should have been a disaster. He delivered the impossible, they'd said. Mydei had circled the phrase in pen until the paper nearly tore.

It felt right. Phainon always delivered something—wonder, chaos, awe, trouble. Even a warm-up could turn apocalyptic if he decided it mattered.

The notebook settles heavier against his ribs as Mydei exhales.

His gaze drifts to a blurred photo of Phainon mid-spin, motion captured instead of detail. He remembers staring at that image for hours, convinced that if he studied it long enough, something sacred would reveal itself.

Back then, it wasn't about fame or hype or noise.

He hadn't cared about the crowds or the interviews or the way entire arenas seemed to hold their breath when Phainon stepped onto the ice.

He just liked watching him.

That was all.

He breathes out slowly.

Feels like forever ago.

And for a brief, quiet stretch of time—with the notebook warm against his chest and the race replay flickering soundlessly across the walls—it feels like the world has looped back on itself, just enough for past and present to exist in the same room.

He had been small enough that the piano bench felt too wide, his feet dangling just above the floor whenever he sat properly. The lesson sheets were folded a little crooked in his hands as he padded down the stairs, careful not to scuff the edges. The house smelled faintly of nutmeg and freshly ground coffee beans. His mother went through seasonal drink

phases every winter, and the kitchen counter always looked like a half-finished science experiment because of it.

She was in the living room, seated on the floor in that effortless way only adults seem to manage, like the carpet had been designed specifically for them. Her hair was twisted into a bun that had absolutely collapsed an hour earlier but was holding together out of stubborn loyalty. The remote rested against her knee. The television—one of the obscenely expensive ones his father insisted was “an investment”—played a winter competition broadcast.

The ice was mic’d too close. Every blade scrape sounded sharp and intimate. The commentators hovered in that familiar American cadence, riding the thin line between informative and breathless, like they were afraid of missing something historic if they spoke too slowly.

He lingered in the doorway at first, performing the ancient childhood ritual of pretending not to care. Just passing through. Nothing to see here. No interest whatsoever.

Then Phainon entered the frame.

Young—about the same age as him—incandescent, cutting into a jump sequence that didn’t make sense to him yet—angles and speed and rotation that his brain couldn’t parse, only feel. It would become iconic later, replayed endlessly in montages and retrospectives. Back then, it was simply a moment that pulled the air out of the room.

Mydei leaned forward without noticing.

His mother glanced back and caught him immediately. She didn’t tease him or even say a word. She just laughed softly—the kind of laugh that made him feel noticed without being embarrassed—and patted the carpet beside her without taking her eyes off the screen.

He sat down at once.

The living room felt warmer than it should have for winter, the glow from the TV flickering across the coffee table with every spin and landing. When Phainon hit the final rotation of that jump, Mydei realized he'd been holding his breath the entire time.

The memory settles as he closes the notebook now, the hotel room quiet around him.

Another one rises to meet it, uninvited but well-worn.

He's older this time, upstairs at his desk with math homework spread out in front of him. The pencil keeps tapping against the paper, stalled on a problem that feels intentionally vague, as if adults designed math to test patience rather than logic. He hears the commentators before he hears anything else—their tone pitching sharp and uneven.

Then the crowd.

He's moving before he fully understands why. Down the stairs, bare feet slapping against the wood, heart racing because he's convinced he's missed something important. A win. A medal. A moment worth sprinting for.

It isn't that.

The sound from the TV isn't celebration. It's that awful, collective intake people make when something goes wrong. The commentators stumble over each other, sentences half-formed and spiraling.

"Khaos is down—he's not getting up—camera off, camera off—"

He doesn't understand what he's seeing. He barely has time to try.

His mother's arm reaches out from behind the couch and covers his eyes before the image can settle. She pulls him in close, steady in a way that feels deliberate. The broadcast cuts away almost immediately after, and the sudden quiet is worse.

He whispers without meaning to.

“Is he okay?”

Her chin rests on the top of his head. Her voice stays gentle. “We hope so.”

That night blurs into the glow of the family computer upstairs. He sits forward in the chair, too close to the screen, refreshing page after page while the room sleeps around him.

Reload. Nothing.

Reload. Still nothing.

Reload—

Forum speculation buried three threads deep. A vague comment. An article promising updates soon without saying anything at all.

Then the federation statement drops.

Hiatus.

He never watched the footage after that. Not because he was afraid. It just didn’t feel like a moment he wanted to crystallize about his childhood hero.

In the present, he presses his forehead lightly against the notebook again, the paper cool against his skin. The weight of it grounds him.

Phainon’s voice from earlier slips back into his thoughts, uninvited and infuriatingly clear.

“Beautiful.”

The word drifts through his head like it belongs there.

He sets the notebook down carefully and stands.

The balcony door slides open with a soft click, letting the warm Barcelona night spill into the room. The air carries layered scents—grilled food from

somewhere below, citrus and salt riding in faintly from the direction of the sea, the low hum of a city that refuses to sleep on a race weekend.

Lights stretch across the skyline, scattered and uneven. Cars murmur through the streets. Someone laughs on a nearby balcony. Dishes clink in a restaurant that should have closed an hour ago and didn't.

Mydei leans against the railing, elbows settling into cool metal. The breeze lifts his hair slightly. He pinches the bridge of his nose, eyes closing.

"Just one meeting," he mutters, almost accusing himself. "And I'm already like this."

His fingers tap once against the railing, searching for rhythm. The night doesn't offer much in return, but it's calm enough that he stays.

Barcelona glows beneath him. The noise softens. And he stands there, acutely aware of the way his chest tightens when he thinks about Phainon's smile—easy, unguarded, unfairly bright.

He stays longer than he needs to.

Thinking about him anyway.

Spain's main airport is already awake in that oddly methodical way cities get when they've been up longer than you have. Bright lights bounce off polished floors. Cleaning crews weave around travelers like ghosts with purpose. Somewhere nearby, an espresso machine screams like it's fighting for its life.

Mydei steps inside and rolls his shoulders once, the chill from the automatic doors giving way to warm air that smells faintly of coffee, citrusy lavender cleaner, and too many people wearing the same recycled breath. He adjusts the brim of his cap without really thinking about it.

Beside him, Hephaestion steers the luggage cart with the focus of someone who has learned, through repeated trial and error, that airports are out to get

you.

“You’re early,” Hephaestion says after a moment, mildly impressed. “Like, voluntarily early.”

Mydei hums. “Don’t sound so surprised. Ignoring the fact my workout sessions are already in the morning, I didn’t want to deal with the hotel lobby at checkout. There’s always that one family who thinks the concierge desk is a personal therapist.”

“That’s fair.” Hephaestion nudges the cart forward, dodging a woman hauling three suitcases and a grudge. “Still. You beating sunrise feels wrong somehow.”

“I’m usually awake before it,” Mydei says. “Just not… dressed.”

Hephaestion smiles to himself. He reaches for Mydei’s shoulder out of habit, realizes the cart’s in the way, and settles for bumping him gently with his elbow instead. “You say that every time, and then I watch you glare at the mirror like a disgruntled cat every morning.”

They merge into the flow of the terminal. People drift diagonally instead of straight, dragging wheeled suitcases that squeal in protest. A businessman paces while arguing into his phone about markets “opening in twenty.” A kid nearby negotiates loudly with a parent about snacks, authority, and the meaning of injustice.

Mydei exhales through his nose. “Why does everyone walk like they’re trying to intercept an invisible opponent.”

“Because it’s an airport,” Hephaestion says. “The rules of physics and walking in a damn straight line are suggestions here.”

They veer off toward a quieter stretch near a cluster of tall indoor plants that look expensive enough to be real. Mydei drops onto the bench with a controlled sort of relief, stretching his legs out and tapping his heel lightly against the floor. The bench is too hard. All airport seating is too hard. This feels deliberate.

“You want food?” Hephaestion asks, already checking his pockets. “We both need breakfast.”

“I don’t,” Mydei says immediately.

Hephaestion waits.

“…Okay, I might,” Mydei adds, annoyed with himself. “But not airplane food.”

“That’s fine,” Hephaestion says. “I wasn’t planning to poison us—*in your own words*—before noon.”

Mydei’s phone buzzes against his thigh. He doesn’t look down.

Hephaestion does anyway, lifting an eyebrow. “Cipher?”

“Obviously,” Mydei says. “Can you read it? I don’t have the mental bandwidth yet.”

Hephaestion fishes the phone out of his hand without ceremony and scans the screen.

[If you land without us, I’m rearranging your schedule myself.]

Hephaestion lets out a quiet huff. “She writes like she’s smiling while holding a knife. Must’ve been a politician’s daughter.”

“That is her smiling,” Mydei replies. He stares out at the terminal, eyes tracking movement without really focusing. “What does she say after that?”

“That’s it.”

“Threat implied, then.”

“Always.”

Hephaestion scrolls through the group chat on his own phone. Mydei taps his heel a little faster, gaze drifting up to the departure board and back

again.

A kid wanders too close, swinging a stuffed elephant in wide, dangerous arcs. Mydei leans away instinctively, posture tensing, like he's dodging something more serious than plush fabric.

"If that thing makes contact," he murmurs, "I'm filing a complaint with someone's guardian."

"You won't," Hephaestion says, not even looking up. "You'd apologize to the kid first."

Mydei doesn't deny it. He watches the child wander off, unharmed and victorious.

Overhead, an announcement crackles to life, cycling through Spanish and then English. Mydei flinches before he can stop himself, shoulders tensing, then settling again once the voice fades.

Hephaestion notices but doesn't comment. Instead, he glances over. "You sure you don't want me to grab coffee now?"

Mydei considers it. He really does.

"…Wait," he decides. "Let's do it when everyone's here. I don't want to lose you in the stampede."

Hephaestion smiles at that. "You act like you're eighty."

"My back acts like it," Mydei replies. "I'm just listening to it."

He shifts, pulling his hoodie sleeves up where he's been fidgeting with them. His foot keeps tapping, subtle but constant. Not nervous, exactly. Just keyed in.

Hephaestion watches him for a second longer than necessary. "You're seriously alright?"

“Yeah,” Mydei says, and this time it’s unforced. “Just too awake for this hour.”

“That checks out.” Hephaestion pockets his phone. “Cipher says two minutes.”

Mydei snorts softly. “So she’s still arguing with a parking attendant.”

“Or committing some morally dubious acts.”

“Or both.”

They share a look—resigned, entirely unsurprised.

Mydei leans back, elbows braced against the bench, eyes drifting across the terminal again. He doesn’t reach for his phone. He doesn’t need to.

Because Cipher never travels alone. And when she moves, the rest follow.

He takes a slow breath and lets it settle.

The Devil moves fast.

Cipher moves faster.

And for exactly three minutes, the airport gives him peace.

Mydei is nursing a bottled tea that has long since given up on being hot. He bought it on instinct, forgot about it immediately, and now keeps taking small, resigned sips like it’s a punishment he’s committed to finishing. His leg is stretched out in front of him, heel tapping the floor in a steady rhythm that looks casual until you’ve spent enough time around him to recognize it as leftover workout energy with nowhere to go.

Hephaestion sits beside him, elbows on his knees, scrolling through an article about tire compounds with intense focus, which meant he absolutely did not mean to fall down this rabbit hole and now can’t escape. He frowns, scrolls back up, then down again, muttering something under his breath about degradation curves.

Mydei glances over. “You’re doing that thing where your eyebrows start arguing with each other.”

“It’s important,” Hephaestion says without looking up. “Apparently this manufacturer swore they fixed the overheating issue, but now everyone’s reporting the same blistering pattern. Again.”

Mydei hums. “So they lied.”

“They marketed creatively.”

“Same thing.”

Hephaestion snorts, then finally locks his phone and exhales. He looks up just in time to clock movement near the entrance. His shoulders shift subtly.

“Brace,” he murmurs.

Mydei doesn’t ask. That word has been earned over years of shared travel, training camps, early mornings, and one unforgettable incident involving a missed connection and three rental cars. He just takes another sip of his tea and waits.

The automatic doors slide open.

And Cipher barrels through the airport like she pays the rent here. She’s got two duffels that clearly did not agree to be carried together, one slipping off her shoulder, the other dragging behind her and threatening to unzip itself. She’s mid-rant, voice carrying easily over the general terminal noise.

“I am telling you, that man looked at me like I personally without my way to commit an international crime. It was a souvenir knife. Do you know how small it is? I’ve had sharper opinions.”

One of the duffels catches on a floor seam. Cipher stumbles—enough that her balance goes sideways for a second in that oddly boneless, feline way, limbs briefly doing their own thing before she rights herself with a huff.

“See?” she snaps at the bag. “This is why I don’t trust objects.”

Hephaestion folds his arms, expression carefully neutral in the way he’s learned to be as reacting only encourages her.

Mydei lowers the bottle from his lips. “She hasn’t seen us yet, has she?”

“Give it a second,” Hephaestion says.

Cipher’s eyes sweep the terminal lazily, scanning faces without urgency. Left. Right. Over someone’s shoulder.

Then they land on Mydei.

Her entire expression lights up, slow and delighted, like she’s just spotted a particularly fat mouse walking free in the wild.

“Well, I’ll be damned,” she calls, already veering toward them. “If it isn’t the Kremnos Apex poster boy himself~”

She drops both duffels mid-stride. They hit the floor with a solid thud that makes a nearby businessman flinch and clutch his carry-on like it’s about to be next.

Mydei lifts a hand in greeting, utterly unbothered. “Morning, Cipher.”

She stops just close enough to bump her shoulder lightly into his, a deliberate, familiar gesture. “You beat us here.”

“You were late to your own assigned meetup time, of course we did.”

She grins. “I’m consistent.”

From beside them, Hephaestion mutters, “From the sound of it, you nearly got arrested.”

“Please,” Cipher says, waving him off. “I merely engaged in a spirited discussion with airport security about cultural misunderstanding.”

“This is Spain,” Hephaestion replies dryly.

“And yet,” she says, tapping her temple, “the spirit of bureaucracy is universal.”

Before Mydei can respond, another presence slides in smoothly from behind Cipher’s ranting.

“Good morning,” Castorice says.

She approaches at a measured pace, hair pinned up neatly today, a soft contrast to everyone else’s barely-contained momentum. She carries a slim folder of boarding passes tucked against her side. When she smiles at Mydei, it’s kind.

“You’re early again,” she says. “I was hoping I wouldn’t be the first one.”

“I had momentum,” Mydei replies. “Didn’t want to waste it.”

Hephaestion reaches for the boarding passes when she offers them, flipping through with a quiet nod of approval. Castorice watches him for a moment, then looks back at Mydei.

“How was the ride in?” she asks. “You mentioned traffic yesterday.”

“Surprisingly calm,” he says. “Driver tried to talk my ear off about local politics, but I escaped.”

She smiles. “You used the headphones trick?”

“I pretended to sleep.”

“Effective,” she says, clearly pleased. “I’m glad you took my advice.”

Cipher makes a noise like she’s choking. “This is the driest exchange I’ve witnessed all week. Do either of you need water? Or enrichment?”

“You’re plenty of stimulation,” Mydei tells her.

“I’ll take that as a compliment.”

Behind them, Aglaea arrives without ceremony, phone pressed to her ear, voice low and razor-sharp in rapid Spanish before switching to English.

“No, listen to me. I understand overbooking. I do. What I don’t understand is why your gate agents are actively avoiding eye contact while I am standing directly in front of them.”

She stops beside the group, nodding to each of them in turn without breaking stride in her argument. Her gaze lands on Cipher for half a second —cool, pointed, deeply unimpressed—before flicking away.

Cipher flashes her an angelic smile that suggests nothing but trouble.

Aglaea turns slightly, still speaking into the phone. “No. No, *cariño*. I am not upset. I am simply informing you that this will be resolved before I count to ten.”

She ends the call and exhales, composure snapping neatly back into place. “Morning.”

“Morning,” Hephaestion says.

Castorice gives a small wave.

Mydei inclines his head. “Morning.”

Aglaea’s mouth curves faintly at that, approval flashing briefly before she turns her attention back to the terminal screens.

Cipher leans closer to Mydei, lowering her voice. “She’s been like that since sunrise. I think an airline executive just felt a disturbance in the force.”

“This is her natural environment,” Mydei murmurs.

“Of course it is,” Cipher says fondly. “Love that for us.”

Hephaestion glances at his watch, already calculating logistics. Mydei shifts his weight, finishing the last of his tea with a resigned swallow.

Then—

A quieter sound cuts through the noise.

Footsteps, unhurried. The soft rustle of a grocery bag. Wheels rolling smoothly over tile.

Mydei doesn’t turn right away, but something in his chest tightens.

A voice follows, calm and unforced.

“Alright,” Phainon says, stepping into view, “I figured I’d bring offerings before someone here yelled at me.”

He’s holding a paper bag full of snacks—energy bars, pastries, fruit cups—clearly chosen with intention. His suitcase trails behind him, wheels aligned perfectly, like he packed and moved with the same care he skates with.

His gaze moves over the group, taking everyone in—

Then it stops on Mydei.

Not lingering long enough to be polite. Not short enough to be accidental.

Something passes across Phainon’s face, subtle but unmistakable. Interest. Assessment. Appreciation, sharpened by curiosity. His eyes trace Mydei’s body, the set of his shoulders, the way his hands rest loose but ready at his sides.

Mydei feels it like a touch he didn’t consent to but doesn’t pull away from.

He stills, just slightly.

Hephaestion notices. Cipher absolutely does.

Her grin spreads slowly, like she’s just been handed front-row seats to something she intends to enjoy very much.

And Mydei, caught in the open like that, does nothing to hide it—just meets Phainon's gaze for half a second longer than necessary before looking away, pulse steady but unmistakably awake.

"Well, damn," Cipher murmurs, eyes flicking between them with predatory delight. "Told you. He's got a crush."

Mydei doesn't react. Not outwardly. Internally, something unlatches and sprints for the nearest exit like it's late for a connecting flight.

"I don't," he says, tone perfectly level. Professional. Olympic-grade denial.

Phainon, who has been calmly redistributing snacks so no one ends up with two identical protein bars, looks up. "A crush?" he asks, genuinely curious. "On who?"

Cipher answers immediately, waving a hand like she's brushing off lint. "Nobody. Completely hypothetical. Ancient history. Don't worry about it."

Aglaea's gaze snaps to Cipher with lethal efficiency. It's the look she uses when she's deciding whether a situation requires intervention or paperwork.

Phainon hums softly, unconvinced but not inclined to push. He has the manners of someone who learned early that questions don't always earn answers, and that curiosity can be satisfied later.

Cipher, thrilled by this restraint, wiggles her eyebrows at Mydei.

Phainon steps closer then, the quiet drag of his suitcase wheels threading through the hum of the terminal. The snack bag rustles as he shifts his grip. His attention settles on Mydei again, unhurried, like he's reorienting himself around a familiar point.

"It's you again," he says.

Mydei waits. A follow-up feels inevitable.

None arrives.

The silence stretches—not awkward, exactly, but noticeable. Even the airport PA seems to hesitate, like it's politely giving them space before announcing another boarding call.

A man with a stroller squeezes past behind them. Somewhere nearby, a barista drops a spoon. Life continues.

Cipher breaks first, elbowing Phainon in the ribs with practiced accuracy.

He startles, just slightly, like a bird interrupted mid-thought. "Ah," he says, blinking. "Right."

He turns back to Mydei, posture adjusting by a fraction. "Castorice mentioned you. I'm glad we're meeting properly this time."

Hephaestion lets out a low whistle, not loud enough to draw attention, but pointed enough to communicate condolences at the accidental indifference.

Mydei stands there with immaculate posture, expression composed, every visible part of him radiating calm competence. Internally, he's weighing the feasibility of committing a light felony against Hephaestion. Purely hypothetical. Out of love.

Cipher leans in toward Mydei's shoulder. "He's trying," she whispers. "Points for effort."

Mydei doesn't dignify that with a response.

"It's nice to meet you too," he says instead, voice smoothed over. This town usually gets him through press conferences without incident.

Phainon inclines his head, eyes lingering in a way that suggests he's taking in more than just Mydei's face.

"Your race earlier," Phainon says. "It was impressive. I wanted to say something more at the venue, but it felt… crowded." He pauses, searching for the word. "Compressed."

The apology in it lands softly, sincere without being heavy. Mydei rolls one shoulder, loosening muscles that have been tight since morning.

“You looked like you were ready to tunnel through a wall,” Mydei replies. “I figured distance was kinder.”

A quiet laugh slips out of Phainon before he can stop it. “So you noticed.”

“It was difficult not to.”

Phainon studies him with open interest, as if this is information he plans to keep. “You’re certainly attentive,” he says. “I appreciate that.”

Something in Mydei’s chest misfires.

“You’re not subtle,” he says. “Presence like that rarely is.”

Phainon tilts his head, considering this like it’s a compliment he hasn’t been given before. “Good,” he says after a moment. “Try as you might, I’d hate to be forgettable to you.”

“…”

Castorice, meanwhile, has shifted closer to Aglaea, quietly updating something on her clipboard. She glances up at Mydei and gives him a small, knowing smile.

Aglaea finishes her call with a sharp tap of her phone screen and exhales. “We will be boarding shortly,” she says calmly. “And yes, I did just renegotiate our seating arrangement.”

Cipher beams. “You’re a miracle worker.”

“I’m tired,” Aglaea replies, sighing. “There is a difference.”

The tension dissolves naturally, laughter rippling through the group in low waves. A boarding announcement cuts through it, echoed in Spanish and English, and Hephaestion checks the gate number again out of habit.

“Group B’s moving,” he says. “If we go now, we beat the surge. Security gets twitchy when Cipher starts storytelling.”

Cipher scoffs. “They should be honored.”

“They should be spared the theatrics, *Cifera*,” Aglaea said, already moving.

Mydei nods and turns, giving Phainon a brief, polite dip of his head. Formal, but not cold.

As he steps away, he feels it—the weight of attention at his back.

Phainon doesn’t say anything. The look lingers, though.

Mydei keeps his eyes forward, pulse steady but alert, neck flushing faintly as they merge into the flow of travelers.

Behind him, the group falls into rhythm—Cipher talking with Castorice, Aglaea gliding through the crowd like she owns the terminal with Hephaestion, and Phainon walking easily among them, suitcase wheels whispering against tile.

Mydei does not look back.

The fact that he wants to feels like information he’s going to have to deal with later.

The apology floats overhead for the third time, airy and well-rehearsed, the kind that’s meant for everyone and no one at once.

“I’m terribly sorry for the inconvenience—”

Mydei moves with the practiced economy of someone who has learned how to exist in narrow spaces without apologizing for his shoulders. Business class smells faintly of lavender wipes, coffee that’s already gone cold, and the hum of recycled air that makes every flight feel like it’s happening inside a very expensive refrigerator. Someone ahead of him keeps turning with a backpack that swings wide enough to qualify as a public safety

hazard, so Mydei angles his carry-on closer to his leg and sidesteps it skillfully.

Behind him, Hephaestion follows, posture rigid, expression locked into that familiar look of *I should be anywhere else*. Cipher brings up the rear, utterly unbothered by the universe's obvious commitment to making this day interesting.

Mydei reaches his row, glances down at the number, then up—

—and stops.

Phainon is already there, settled into the window seat with the confidence of someone who boarded early and assumed the world would cooperate. One arm rests easily on the armrest, long legs angled just enough to avoid blocking the aisle. He looks up at the same moment Mydei looks at him.

They register each other in the same beat.

They quickly share the realization of logistical overlap.

The flight attendant hustles back down the aisle, breath a little fast, tablet hugged to her chest. "Yes—about that. We had a system error and accidentally assigned two passengers to fourteen A."

Across the aisle, Hephaestion drops into fourteen C and immediately lowers his head. Cipher slides into fourteen D with suspicious grace, presses her lips together, and vibrates with suppressed laughter.

Mydei doesn't hesitate. He barely even sighs.

"He can keep it," he says, already shifting his bag.

Phainon blinks once. Polite. Almost startled, like he had expected at least a brief standoff over the window. "Oh. Thank you."

It's genuine, too, which somehow makes Mydei's chest do something unhelpful.

He slips into the next seat after sorting it out with the flight attendant, and buckles in without fuss. Business class, at least, offers the dignity of armrests that exist and legroom that doesn’t feel punitive. He settles back, shoulders easing.

Small mercies.

Phainon glances over again, like he’s still recalibrating. “If you want the window later,” he adds, “I don’t mind switching.”

Mydei meets his gaze, the corner of his mouth lifting just enough to count as a smile. “I’m good. Aisle’s fine.”

Phainon studies him for a second longer than necessary, then nods, apparently satisfied. He turns back toward the window, though his knee remains angled just slightly toward Mydei, a detail that Mydei notices and absolutely does not overthink.

Hephaestion exhales through his nose. Cipher finally breaks, leaning forward just enough to murmur, “This is already better than in-flight entertainment.”

Mydei doesn’t look at her. He closes his eyes instead, lets his head rest back against the seat, and listens to the soft choreography of a plane preparing to leave the ground—bins clicking shut, seatbelts snapping, the murmur of strangers settling into shared air.

Beside him, Phainon shifts, the faint brush of fabric close enough to feel without touching.

It’s just a seat mix-up.

Just a flight.

And somehow, already, it feels like the universe is smirking.

An hour into the flight, the cabin settles into its second personality.

The initial bustle has thinned into a low, collective murmur. Overhead lights glow dimmer now, softened to something gentler on the eyes. A flight attendant nudges a cart down the aisle with careful precision, glassware chiming softly as she pauses to pour water, then wine, then coffee that smells stronger than it has any right to at this altitude. Across the aisle, a man in a pressed jacket leans toward his seatmate and whispers with the intensity of someone discussing a hostile takeover. Two rows back, a child hums to herself, tuneless and content, her socked feet tapping the seat in front of her in a rhythm only she understands.

The plane hums steadily beneath it all, a constant presence rather than a disturbance.

Phainon sits with the window shade half-lowered, sunlight catching along the edge of his hair and the sharp line of his cheek. One hand rests in his lap, fingers loosely intertwined, the other braced against the armrest. He looks out at the clouds with quiet attention, almost absentmindedly.

Mydei sits beside him, posture relaxed in theory, attentive in practice. He reads the same paragraph on his screen for the third time and absorbs none of it. His awareness keeps orbiting sideways, drawn by small details he pretends not to catalogue. The steady rhythm of Phainon’s breathing. The way his foot shifts when the plane makes a gentle adjustment. The faint scent of soap and something honey-adjacent.

Around them, their entourage does a poor job pretending they are uninvolved.

Hephaestion adjusts his headphones, glancing over the top of them like a long-suffering chaperone. Cipher watches openly, tablet forgotten, chin propped in her palm. Castorice cranes just enough to confirm her suspicions, then settles back with an expression of vindicated patience. Even Aglaea, further back, meets Mydei’s eyes for half a second and lifts her brows with serene expectation.

The universe continues its refusal to offer a convenient opening.

But then the plane gives a small, passing jolt.

It rolls through the cabin with the mild indifference of weather doing what it does. Drinks ripple in their cups. The overhead bins murmur. A few passengers shift, then settle again.

Mydei's body reacts faster than his mind.

His shoulders draw in. His hand tightens around the armrest. His breath stutters before smoothing out again, measured and controlled.

Phainon turns his head.

The movement stays small, respectful of shared space, but his attention sharpens immediately. His gaze flicks to Mydei's hand, then to his face, clocking his reading posture and tension.

"Does turbulence bother you?" he asks, voice low enough that it stays between them, calm without softness that might sound patronizing.

Mydei exhales, slightly relieved as the opportunity to talk revealed itself. "It catches me off guard sometimes. I spend most of my time with the ground doing exactly what I expect it to."

Phainon's mouth curves, just barely. The expression carries recognition. "That makes sense. Things feels different when it comes from an engine you can feel responding."

Mydei turns his head fully this time. "You too then? Turbulence, I mean."

"I do," Phainon replies. He shifts in his seat, angling himself a little more toward Mydei without fully abandoning the window. "I had the same adjustment period when my schedule started involving longer flights. The lack of feedback takes getting used to."

Mydei feels the tightness in his shoulders ease. "That's a good way to put it. Feedback. I trust turbulence more when I know what caused it."

Phainon nods, thoughtful. "Patterns help. I tend to map them even when it's unnecessary. Besides, the pilots usually know what they're doing."

“Usually… that sounds reassuring,” Mydei says, a smile pulling at his mouth.

Phainon’s gaze lingers on that smile longer than required. He doesn’t look away quickly.

“My schedule lets me fly more often than I’d like,” Phainon continues. “You develop habits. Certain playlists. Certain books. Something repetitive enough to distract you.”

“What works for you?” Mydei asks, curious.

Phainon considers the question as if it deserves proper treatment. “Manual hobbies. Things that occupy the hands without demanding the mind. I picked up crocheting a few years ago.”

Mydei blinks. “Seriously?” He almost winced at his tone. He hadn’t meant it in a strange way. Just—well—he didn’t seem the type.

“Entirely,” Phainon says. “Scarves at first. Then blankets. My friends benefit greatly from my inability to stand still.”

Mydei’s interest sharpens, immediate and unfiltered. “That’s actually impressive. I tried knitting once and managed to turn yarn into something… interesting to say the least. My parents weren’t pleased.”

Phainon’s lips part, a soft sound leaving him that sits somewhere between a laugh and a fond hum. “That stage passes. Muscle memory settles in, and it becomes meditative.”

“I can see that,” Mydei says. “There’s something comforting about repetitive motion. I do that with mechanical work sometimes. Taking things apart, putting them back together even when they don’t need it.”

Phainon’s attention fixes on him fully now. “You do your own adjustments?”

“When I can,” Mydei answers. “It helps me understand where limits actually live. Plus Peuc—sorry, my manager appreciates when I keep

myself busy in productive ways.”

Phainon studies him, eyes tracing Mydei’s expression as though committing it to memory. “That aligns with how you race.”

Mydei’s pauses. “You’ve watched me more than once?”

“I have,” Phainon says. He shifts his arm on the armrest, close enough that the heat from his sleeve brushes Mydei’s forearm. “Your decision-making tightened midway through the season. The exits became more confident. You trusted the car and yourself earlier.”

The cabin fades a little around them. Mydei’s pulse makes itself known.

“That adjustment came after a shoulder issue,” Mydei says. “I had to rework how I compensated. Hearing someone noticed such a small detail feels… surprising.”

Phainon continued further, giving Mydei a languid smile. “Details like that stand out when someone interests me.”

He says it plainly without flourish. His gaze meets Mydei’s and stays there, unabashed.

Mydei absorbs the words slowly. “I spent time studying your footage too,” he admits, the honesty slipping out with a sincerity that surprises him. “Your consistency taught me a lot.”

Phainon’s expression changes to be slightly more softer. “I’m glad it reached you.”

Cipher finally looks away, satisfied. Hephaestion exhales and settles deeper into his seat. Somewhere behind them, a flight attendant laughs quietly with a passenger.

Phainon turns back toward the window, though his knee stays angled toward Mydei, presence still attentive. “If the flight grows restless later,” he says casually, “I can show you a stitch pattern. It passes time surprisingly well.”

Mydei perks up slightly. “I’d like that.”

And then because he can’t keep his mouth shut—

“Your footwork in Shanghai was clean, too.”

The words escape Mydei before he has time to filter them through dignity, discretion, or any of the internal safeguards that usually prevent him from confessing years of accumulated admiration in public seating arrangements.

Phainon turns toward him fully this time. His eyebrows lift, just slightly, a small break in his carefully even composure.

“Shanghai,” he repeats, rolling the word once like he’s checking its weight. “That was… a while ago.”

“Yeah,” Mydei says, nodding with an ease he does not feel. His hand makes a small, unconscious gesture in the air, fingers tracing an invisible arc before he realizes he’s doing it and pulls it back to the armrest. “Still good.”

A beat passes.

The program had aired briefly, shuffled into an awkward time slot, then vanished into archive purgatory after production issues. People who remembered it tended to remember the controversy, the cancellation, the disappointment. Very few remembered the skating itself.

Phainon’s expression shifts. Surprise flickers there, followed by something else. His expression was unreadable now as his gaze lingered.

They both turn away at the same time—two men who absolutely do not know how to deal with sincerity.

Mydei decided to focus on somewhere behind them, where someone laughs softly at something on their phone. A welcomed distraction.

Phainon shifts in his seat, a subtle roll of his ankle like he’s checking the joint out of habit. The motion stays small, but Mydei clocks it instantly, the

detail slipping neatly into that mental drawer he keeps labeled things to revisit later when he has time to worry properly.

He closes the drawer.

Their elbows brush against the shared armrest.

The contact carries weight disproportionate to its size.

Mydei clears his throat, mostly to force himself forward before his brain builds an obstacle course out of hesitation.

“You know,” he starts, voice settling into something steadier, “that performance you did that season… I really enjoyed it.”

Phainon turns toward him again, this time without surprise. Curiosity sits openly on his face, patient and attentive in a way that makes words line up more easily for Mydei.

“It was elegant,” Mydei continues, leaning slightly forward now, hands moving again despite himself. “Your transitions stayed fluid even when the tempo shifted. Most skaters tighten there, but you let the phrasing continue. The way you carried momentum through the diagonals made the whole thing feel intentional, and it matched the music in guiding it.”

He stops gesturing when he realizes how animated he’s become, fingers curling against his palm. A quiet laugh slips out of him, soft and disbelieving. “Sorry. I—this stuff sticks with me.”

Phainon listens without interruption.

“I appreciated the restraint,” Mydei adds, slower now, choosing his words carefully. “There was direction in it I admired. Everything had purpose.”

His heart rate picks up, recognizing familiar emotional territory.

“And honestly—before that too. Everything you did stood out. You had this way of committing fully without overplaying it. I used to—”

He stops.

Abruptly.

Because the next sentence waiting in the wings is *I used to watch you for hours when I was figuring out if my dream was worth fighting my whole life for*, and that feels like a confession best saved for a universe with fewer seatbelts.

He reroutes with practiced grace.

“Anyway,” he says, smoothing his tone, professionalism sliding neatly back into place, “I wanted to ask how you’ve been doing since—well….”

The question hangs there, gentle and unfinished.

The seatbelt sign chimes overhead.

Almost immediately, the plane hits a pocket of turbulence.

A toddler across the aisle squeals with delight, feet kicking happily as the cabin jostles. A flight attendant appears with impeccable timing, reminding everyone to remain seated, voice calm and reassuring.

The moment disperses just like that.

Mydei exhales, settling back into his seat, letting the interruption carry the intensity somewhere safer.

Phainon keeps his gaze on the window for a moment longer, watching coastline lights scatter beneath them like spilled constellations. When he speaks, his voice arrives softer, reflective.

“I like window seats,” he murmurs.

The shift feels natural, eased by the interruption rather than forced by it.

“They help me stay oriented,” he continues, fingers resting lightly against the armrest. “I sketch sometimes. Cities from above. Patterns in how places

grow. It makes travel feel… tangible.”

Then he turns, offering Mydei a small, genuine smile.

“Thanks for letting me take this one.”

Mydei’s heart attempts to replicate the turbulence internally. Externally, he manages a composed nod.

“Of course.”

The rest of the flight stretches gently after that. Conversation resurfaces in quieter forms—shared stories about unexpected hobbies, Mydei admitting to his interest in Instruments and performing, Phainon listening with interest that lingers longer than required. Words come and go, punctuated by comfortable pauses that surprisingly don’t feel awkward.

By the time the wheels touch down, they’ve had three real conversations, fourteen accidental glances, and an impressive number of half-formed thoughts left suspended between them.

Cabin lights brighten. Passengers rise in slow, impatient clusters.

Phainon reaches for his bag first, pausing before stepping into the aisle. The pause feels deliberate.

He turns toward Mydei.

“Hey,” he says. “Thanks for the company.”

Mydei huffs a soft laugh. “We barely talked.”

Phainon’s smile deepens, like sunrise edging over a horizon.

“Still counts.”

Then, quietly—

“See you, Mydeimos.”

He merges into the flow of passengers, disappearing inch by inch as the crowd carries him away.

Mydei remains seated for a moment longer, pulse still racing like it has somewhere urgent to be. He stands once his expression settles, joining the slow procession toward the exit.

He tells himself the flight was uneventful.

His heartbeat suggests otherwise.

Chapter End Notes

> I edited this really late and I’m way too tired to read this over again so feel free to point out any mistakes or give constructive criticism. I feel I repeated a ton of words so if you guys see any of those please just tell me abt it and I’ll get myself to go back and edit this again 😭
>
> Hmmm not much going on in hindsight rn but we’ll get somewhere eventually trust, thanks for reading!!

Chapter 2: Watching Your Future Boyfriend Glide Gracefully While You Melt

Chapter Summary

> Four days of content farming, scenic “competitions,” and Cipher refusing to be stopped.
>
> By Day Five, Mydei is watching figure skating practice in a cold rink, Phainon is being effortlessly charming on and off the ice, and both of them are losing a battle they didn’t realize they were fighting.

Chapter Notes

> HAPPY LATE NEW YEAR!!! The pacing is a bit iffy in this but I hope y’all enjoy reading <333

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Salzburg International Sports Complex presented itself like a statement piece rather than a venue.

Everything gleamed with intention. Glass facades caught the Alps at precise angles, snow-bright peaks reflected so cleanly they looked painted. Walkways curved in gentle, deliberate lines, guiding foot traffic the way a conductor guides an orchestra. Even the cold carried structure—clean, alpine air that filled the lungs and snapped the senses awake.

It suited the crowd perfectly.

High-performance environments always attracted a certain species of person: sports scientists with color-coded lanyards, biomechanics specialists arguing about tendon elasticity over breakfast, federation officials in tailored coats discussing marginal gains like sacred scripture. Everywhere Mydei turned, someone wore a badge declaring a job title that sounded invented yet paid extremely well.

This week, Austria hosted two events simultaneously: the International High-Performance Athletic Symposium and a winter sports heritage showcase. Salzburg, ever proud of its ability to blend history with prestige, treated the overlap like a feature rather than a scheduling accident.

And because Austria adored symbolic invitations, Kremnos Apex received one.

Greek roots. Global reach. A racing dynasty polished enough for museum glass. And one infuriatingly photogenic heir who insisted his emotional attachment lay with tire degradation curves and braking points rather than the fact that half the attendees could trace their sponsorship pipeline back to his surname.

That heir walked the concourse right now, hands tucked into his coat, expression calm in a way that made publicists nervous.

Mydei.

Red Bull’s influence threaded through the symposium like an invisible watermark, turning the entire week into a bundled experience: paddock tours, cross-discipline panels, athlete showcases, and carefully “spontaneous” introductions. The atmosphere felt less like a conference and more like a grand experiment where someone mixed every competitive industry together and waited to see who bonded over protein shakes.

The morning passed smoothly enough.

Luggage reached them intact. Breakfast involved nodding politely through small talk while Leonnius explained, with evangelical passion, why Austrian pastries deserved a dedicated training exemption. Then came the biomechanics lecture Leonnius promised would change Mydei’s life and instead delivered a sobering reminder that letting Leonnius choose compulsory sessions ranked among his more questionable decisions.

Mydei endured it with the patience of an older sibling listening to a younger one explain something discovered five minutes ago.

After lunch, staff directed them toward the media pavilion for what the schedule described as a casual introduction.

Casual arrived carrying optimism.

They stepped outside, boots crunching softly against treated stone, Salzburg stretching wide and immaculate around them. Church spires punctured the skyline. Bells chimed somewhere distant. For a few seconds, the world felt composed.

Then sound arrived first.

A layered roar rolled around the corner—voices overlapping, camera shutters rattling, someone calling out in sharp Austrian German with the practiced urgency of local press. A cluster of fans surged forward, winter coats puffed like armor, phones already raised.

“Mydei—Herr Mydei—ein Moment!”

“Der junge Formel-1-Star—hier!”

The crowd thickened instantly, momentum building like snow sliding off a roof.

Leonnius froze for exactly half a second before instincts kicked in.

“MOVE—move, move, MOVE—!” he shouted, voice slicing through the noise as he threw his arms wide, attempting crowd control through sheer conviction.

Microphones appeared. A camera shoved close enough for Mydei to count eyelashes.

“Herr Mydei! Championship thoughts? Team rumors?”

Another voice snapped into English, bright and breathless. “Austria wants you for the cultural promo tonight—is that confirmed?”

Flash. Flash. Flash.

Leonnius planted his feet directly in the chaos, jacket flaring as he spun like a windmill with a press badge.

“BACK—back, BACK—!” he roared, vowels stretching with effort. “He is off-schedule! This introduction happens later! You are improvising and I refuse to participate—MYDEI! STOP MOVING LIKE YOU’RE MADE OF SOAP AND HELP—!”

Mydei sighed softly.

Years of threading a car through shrinking gaps at impossible speeds translated beautifully to this moment. He pivoted, slipped between two camera operators arguing about framing, hooked a steady arm around Leonnius’s elbow, and guided them sideways through a narrow opening like a practiced dance.

“I mentioned the private route,” Mydei said calmly as they moved.

“That route required staff clearance we lacked,” Leonnius puffed, boots skidding slightly as he kept up. “Also, I expected restraint. Alpine serenity. Neutral energy.”

“Austrians stay calm,” Mydei replied. “Until sports enter the equation.”

“That looked calm to you?!”

“You would enjoy Italian press,” Mydei added, voice thoughtful. “They treat publicists like communal property.”

“For what purpose?”

“Negotiation.”

They reached the frosted glass wall marking federation-only access. Security stood posted there, jackets crisp, expressions carved from stone. A single look sent the crowd stalling like traffic meeting a closed tunnel.

Inside, warmth replaced the bite of winter. The hallway hummed with low conversation and distant footsteps, insulated from the frenzy outside.

Leonnius leaned against the wall, hands braced on his knees, breath coming in exaggerated pulls.

“This,” he said between inhales, “qualifies as hostile terrain.”

Mydei waited beside him, unruffled, watching color return to his friend’s face.

“When we get home,” Leonnius continued, straightening with renewed dignity, “I will draft a letter. Ten pages. Structured. Passionate.”

“You will reach page two,” Mydei said gently, as if talking to an injured animal.

Leonnius paused. Considered. “A pastry will intervene.”

“Always does.”

They shared a grin and started down the hallway at an easier pace, footsteps echoing softly.

Leonnius lets the silence breathe for exactly three steps.

Then—casually, cruelly—he glances sideways.

“Oh,” he says, tone light. “Speaking of distractions. You know Aglaea’s skating crew? The one you’re very normal about?”

Mydei doesn’t even turn his head. “I am extremely normal about everyone.”

“That pause you just took,” Leonnius continues, unfazed, “was not convincing.”

“I paused because I’m walking,” Mydei says. “People do that.”

“Sure,” Leonnius hums. “Anyway. Cipher went live.”

That earns him a look.

Leonnius smiles with the quiet satisfaction of an older brother who has located the exact pressure point and applied it gently, lovingly, with intent.

“She does that thing,” he adds, already unlocking his phone, “where she pretends it’s spontaneous but somehow the lighting is perfect and her mic is crystal clear. Very organic. Very her.”

“I don’t care,” Mydei says immediately.

“You shouldn’t,” Leonnius agrees. “Except Phainon is with them, and statistically speaking, Cipher has never missed an opportunity to aim a camera at something interesting.”

Mydei stops walking.

Just for a beat.

Leonnius does not comment on this. He simply taps the screen and tilts the phone.

The livestream opens mid-motion.

———

● LIVE—@cipherontherun
3.8k viewers
chat scrolling fast...

Cipher’s face fills the screen, framed by soft daylight and her own impeccable confidence. She walks backward down a wide corridor, camera steady, voice playful.

“Okay, okay—hi, hello, good morning to everyone who skipped work for this, I see you,” she says, flashing a grin. “We’re backstage at the Salzburg complex, which means yes, it’s cold, yes, it’s fancy, and yes, everyone here looks like they drink something green before sunrise.”

The comments scroll fast.

Ciphersthickthighs: omg is this the symposium
trashcanenthusiast: show us the athletes
trailblaze_deeznuts: cipher the eyeliner???
pompomfanclub: is castorice there???

Cipher pivots the camera with a practiced flick of her wrist.

Castorice appears in frame, bundled neatly in a cream coat, clipboard tucked to her chest. She blinks, then smiles and gives a small wave.

“Oh—hi,” she says softly. “Good morning. We’re in the warm-up corridor. The airflow here is actually designed to reduce muscle stiffness before—”

Cipher leans into frame, “She’s being humble. She could talk about this for an hour and I’d monetize every minute.”

Castorice laughs, cheeks pink, and continues anyway, voice gentle and focused. “It helps with temperature regulation between sessions. Especially for ankles and knees.”

The chat explodes.

silverwolf_alt_acc_7: CASTORICE MY BELOVED
kafka_step_on_me: ankles??
march7thbias: is PHD there???

Mydei’s attention sharpens so fast it surprises even him.

The camera swings again, catching movement at the edge of the frame—white jacket, familiar posture, the suggestion of a profile—

Cipher reacts instantly.

“Oh! Nope,” she sings, turning the phone toward the floor with theatrical grace. “Some people are off-limits today, folks. Mystery is good for engagement.”

cloudknightirl: NOOOO
this_is_not_mara: cipher we saw that

imbibitor_lmfao: was that PHD??
FoxgirlUnionRep: rewind!!!

Cipher grins at the screen, unfazed. “Respecting boundaries builds trust. Trust builds loyalty. Loyalty builds—well, you know.”

She winks and lifts the camera again, this time catching her boots, the polished floor, the hum of voices around them.

“Anyway, we’re heading to warm-ups. Stick around. Or don’t. I’ll be here regardless.”

———

The stream cuts as Leonnius lowers the phone.

He glances up.

Mydei is staring at nothing in particular with the intensity of someone replaying a single blurred frame in high definition inside his skull.

“They seem fine,” Leonnius says mildly. “Busy. Productive. Living their lives.”

Mydei swallows. “Good.”

His voice behaves. His face behaves. His internal world is doing something else entirely.

He adjusts his jacket, then does it again, because his hands need somewhere to go.

“That was,” he says, carefully neutral, “informative.”

Leonnius snorts. “You leaned forward.”

“I did not.”

“You absolutely did.”

They resume walking, footsteps echoing toward the elevator bank. Around them, delegates drift past in clusters, laughter bouncing off glass walls, the low murmur of multilingual conversations threading through the space. Someone nearby argues cheerfully about funding allocations. Another group poses for photos beside a banner.

Life keeps moving.

Mydei keeps pace, eyes forward.

“Well,” he adds, tone easy, a thin smile threatening to give him away, “it’s not as if we’re meeting anytime soon.”

The elevator doors slide open with a soft chime.

Leonnius steps inside first, glancing back with a look that carries years of shared history, shared secrets, and the unshakable certainty that this will be unbearable interesting.

“Mhm,” he says. “Let’s see how long that lasts.”

Well.

That was optimistic of him.

Mydei had said—confidently, even—*it’s not as if we’re meeting anytime soon.*

Austria, apparently, took that as a personal challenge.

The festival hadn’t officially started, which meant Salzburg existed in its liminal state: too early for crowds, too late for privacy. Athletes, teams, sponsors, and organizers drifted through the city like migratory birds who all booked the same cafés. Lanyards tucked into jackets. Sunglasses worn indoors. That specific buzz of people pretending they weren’t already on.

Mydei’s hotel sat just off the old town, stone walls and pleasantly quiet hallways. From his window, he could see the edge of the Hohensalzburg

Fortress if he leaned far enough, the silhouette cutting clean against the morning sky.

Everything was scheduled. Predictable, even.

Which made it deeply irritating that he had already spotted Phainon three separate times in under twenty-four hours.

Not close encounters. Flashes. White hair across a lobby. A familiar stride disappearing through glass doors. A gentle laugh—unmistakable, kind—echoing somewhere behind him while he pretended very hard not to turn around.

Hephaestion noticed by the second sighting.

By the third, he'd stopped pretending not to.

"This is getting statistically interesting," Hephaestion said mildly over breakfast, eyes following Mydei's gaze as it tracked, again, to absolutely nothing. "You want to tell me something?"

Mydei buttered his toast with unnecessary focus. "Austria is small."

"Salzburg is not *that* small."

"Relative to the universe," Mydei said, and stood up before the conversation could continue.

The collision happened an hour later.

He'd ducked out early, intent on walking through the contemporary wing of the Mozarteum before it filled with people who liked to stand too close while pretending not to read plaques. The hallway was long, sculptures arranged meticulously under soft, indirect lighting.

He rounded a corner.

And walked directly into a chest.

Unfortunately, not a shoulder. Nor an arm.

A chest.

Solid, warm, and—unhelpfully—at the exact height where Mydei's forward momentum carried him straight in. His hands came up on reflex, palms spreading to brace—

—and found give.

He didn't register it immediately.

What he registered was the warmth. The faint smell of clean fabric and some type of perfume. The way the impact knocked the air out of him just enough that his body decided leaning was easier than correcting.

For half a second—maybe longer—his cheek pressed in.

It was… comfortable.

Soft in a way that didn't match the rest of the frame beneath it. Solid underneath, sure, but cushioned. The kind of deceptive softness that absorbed pressure instead of rejecting it.

Mydei exhaled.

Almost sighed.

His eyes drifted shut on instinct, brain lagging behind sensation like a system booting up.

Somewhere above him, someone made a startled sound—short, sharp, surprised—but didn't step back.

Didn't move at all, actually.

Which was odd.

Mydei adjusted his grip slightly, fingers curling without thinking, as if to steady himself better. His thumbs pressed in—

Oh.

Oh *no*.

Awareness snapped into place like a safety harness engaging too late.

He stiffened, heat flooding his face as his brain finally caught up to the fact that he was not, in fact, leaning against a wall or a conveniently placed cushion.

He was holding a man’s chest.

With both hands.

And his cheek was still there.

He jerked back like he’d been burned, hands dropping instantly as he took a step away, throat clearing hard enough to feel it.

“I—sorry. I wasn’t—” Mydei stopped himself, because continuing would only make it worse.

Phainon stood where he’d been, looking down at him with a surprised expression. His posture stayed loose, unbothered, like nothing unusual had happened at all.

White hair, slightly mussed. Broad shoulders under a fitted jacket. That familiar, unfairly handsome face.

His eyes flicked briefly to Mydei’s hands, then back up.

“…You okay?” Phainon asked.

His voice was low, still rough around the edges like he’d only been awake long enough to exist, not enough to filter himself.

Mydei nodded once. Then again, because the first one felt insufficient. “Yeah. Fine. Sorry about that.”

Phainon hummed, considering. “You caught yourself fast.”

Mydei blinked. “I… what?”

“You shifted your weight before you fell,” Phainon said, entirely serious. “Good reflexes.”

A beat.

“That was not—” Mydei stopped. Tried again. “That was an accident.”

“I know.”

Phainon smiled.

It was easy. Uncomplicated. Like the idea of Mydei slamming into him had not lodged anywhere embarrassing in his mind at all.

“It’s my fault too,” he added. “I wasn’t watching where I was going.”

His gaze dipped then returned to Mydei’s face.

“You’re sturdier than you look,” Phainon continued, tone conversational. “I expected more impact.”

Mydei’s brain short-circuited.

“I—excuse me?”

Phainon tilted his head. “Hm?”

Mydei swallowed.

Up close, Phainon carried that sun-warmed grain scent again, with a hint of something sweet Mydei couldn’t quite name—like a field on the verge of harvest. Or maybe it was more floury? He couldn’t decide, because

suddenly he was painfully aware of the space between them—and how recently there hadn’t been any at all.

Phainon’s attention drifted to the sculpture beside them, a smooth marble form catching the morning light. He studied it for a moment, hands settling casually at his sides.

Then, like an afterthought, he added, “Also. Comfortable.”

Mydei stared at him.

“…What?”

Phainon gestured vaguely, palm up, like he was explaining something obvious. “Leaning on you. It was comfortable.”

A pause.

“Good density,” he said, nodding once, as if confirming a hypothesis. “Balanced.”

Somewhere deep in Mydei’s skull, every coherent thought fled the premises.

“That—” He cleared his throat. “That’s… good to know.”

Phainon looked back at him then, brows lifting slightly, like he was surprised Mydei hadn’t already known.

“Morning, by the way.”

“Morning,” Mydei echoed, because words had abandoned him and muscle memory was doing its best.

They stood there for a second longer than necessary.

Close enough that Mydei could still feel phantom warmth where his hands had been.

Close enough that Phainon didn’t seem to notice anything strange about it.

Eventually, they both stepped back at the same time, a mutual adjustment that felt almost choreographed. A nod exchanged. Polite. Normal. Entirely at odds with the way Mydei’s everything refused to calm down.

They walked in opposite directions.

Both of them took one extra step before remembering how legs worked.

It should have ended there.

It absolutely did not.

A day later, Mydei held open the entrance to the organizer’s administration building because he had hands and basic courtesy.

Someone brushed past him—tall, broad enough that Mydei registered shoulder first, then chest—*ahem*, then the clean line of a jaw that felt offensively familiar.

Phainon slowed halfway through the doorway.

Not fully stopping, but easing his pace.

“…Thanks, little prince,” he commented.

The nickname landed sideways.

Mydei had heard it everywhere—broadcasts, interviews, fans who liked irony more than accuracy. It had stuck back when he was barely legal to race at that level, too polished, too calm, a corporate machine who smiled pleasantly while dismantling grids full of older drivers. Someone said he drove like the car was an extension of himself.

Little prince survived the season.

Phainon said it like he was tasting it.

His voice dipped on prince, just slightly, like he hadn’t meant to do it and definitely hadn’t noticed.

“My name works too,” Mydei said, keeping his tone neutral through sheer force of will.

Phainon glanced back.

That look.

“Mmm,” he hummed, eyes dragging over Mydei’s face like he was inventorying something interesting. “Mydei-mos.”

He said it slow. Drew it out, syllables heavy, mouth clearly enjoying the taste of the name.

Mydei’s fingers tightened on the door handle.

Phainon smiled, satisfied in a way that suggested he’d just stretched something that felt good.

“Thanks anyway,” he added, and walked inside with long, relaxed strides, apparently done with the interaction.

Ten minutes later, the world proved it had a sense of humor.

The elevator doors slid open.

Mydei stepped in.

Phainon was already there, leaning against the back wall.

They nodded at each other, polite in the way people get when they’re very aware of the air between them.

The doors slid shut.

The elevator began to move.

Mydei fixed his gaze straight ahead, posture straight, hands folded neatly like he was awaiting a verdict. He could feel Phainon beside him without looking—including the faint shift of weight as he settled more comfortably.

Phainon looked at him.

Then down.

Then back up again.

“Do you lift?” Phainon asked.

Mydei’s jaw tightened. “…What?”

Phainon turned fully toward him, eyebrows lifting, clearly surprised this required clarification. “Lift. We bumped into each other the other day. Looks like you’ve been spending time at the gym.”

Mydei swallowed. “I’m an athlete.”

“I know,” Phainon said easily. “Still.”

His eyes dropped again, slower this time, unapologetic.

“Your arms are ridiculous,” he continued, like he was commenting on the weather. “Not just big—thick. Like you actually use them. Forearms too. Veins show when you’re holding the door, by the way.”

Mydei stared straight ahead, pulse thudding violently in his ears.

“You don’t seem to miss workouts,” Phainon went on, warming to the subject. “Shoulders are wide enough that jackets pull weird across your back. Chest impressive, even under a shirt. That’s hard to do.”

“…You’re very observant,” Mydei said, trying hard not to glance at his own chest in lieu of his words.

Phainon smiled. “I look.”

The elevator passed another floor.

“You feel really strong,” Phainon continued, tilting his head slightly. “Yesterday… a strange thought occurred to me, you could probably lift me with one hand. You just seem… good at holding someone. Not that I’d ever make you try. Impressive, though.”

Mydei’s breath hitched before he could stop it.

Phainon noticed.

“Oh,” he said, blinking once. “You okay?”

“You… you just said I’d be good at holding someone,” Mydei said, voice tight.

Phainon considered that. “Yeah.”

A pause.

“I mean physically,” he clarified, then immediately ruined it. “Though I guess both.”

Mydei’s ears burned.

“When you leaned in,” Phainon continued, entirely unbothered, “you kind of went soft for a second. Relaxed I mean. I thought you were about to fall asleep on me.”

Mydei choked on air. “I did not—”

“You did,” Phainon said idly. “Your shoulders dropped. Your face went blank. It was cute.”

Cute.

Mydei felt his soul attempt to leave through his feet.

The elevator slowed.

Phainon leaned back against the wall, arms folding easily, muscles shifting under fabric like he was deliberately showing off without realizing it. “You should let yourself do that more,” he said. “You carry stress everywhere. Neck, shoulders, jaw. I noticed.”

He reached out and tapped two fingers against Mydei’s shoulder, absentminded.

Mydei nearly folded.

The doors chimed and slid open two floors early.

Phainon stepped out, then paused, turning back with open curiosity, like the conversation wasn’t deranged.

“Oh—if you ever want a spot,” he added, brightening, “I’m good at it. I like watching people lift heavy. Especially arms like yours. Big fan.”

Mydei forced himself to look at him.

“…I’ll keep that in mind.”

Phainon smiled, pleased, and walked off.

The doors slid shut.

Mydei stayed where he was.

Then he pressed his forehead gently against the elevator wall and exhaled through his teeth.

The elevator continued upward.

Unconcerned.

The strangest coincidence happened on the third day.

A volunteer intercepted Mydei near the press tent, cheerful and moving too fast for correction, and pressed a guest pass into his hands. The lanyard was bright blue, the kind that clashed with everything and demanded to be noticed.

“Skating delegation check-in is down that hall!”

She pointed with confidence and vanished before consequences could catch up.

Hephaestion squinted at the badge. “…You’re not a skater.”

Mydei stared at the lanyard. “Correct.”

He turned to return it immediately.

Outside the tent, a familiar tall figure stood wrestling with the zipper of a white jacket that refused to cooperate, shoulders flexing slightly every time he tugged at it like the jacket had personally offended him.

Phainon looked up.

Paused.

Held Mydei’s gaze for a beat longer than courtesy required.

“…Why are you here?” he asked.

“Wrong badge.”

Phainon nodded once, accepting this with impressive efficiency, like misplaced credentials were simply part of the ecosystem.

A PR woman nearby perked up, clipboard tucked against her chest. “Oh! Are you part of the skaters’ block today?”

“No,” Mydei said automatically.

The word came out higher pitched than intended.

Phainon’s shoulders jumped. He turned his face away under the pretense of fixing the zipper again, a faint sound escaping him that sat somewhere between a cough and a laugh.

“For what it’s worth,” he said mildly, glancing back at Mydei, “you’d blend in just fine.”

The PR woman laughed, already distracted by something else.

Mydei did not trust his mouth.

The buffet incident happened later on.

It was crowded in the way only athlete events ever got—plates balanced on forearms, people talking with their mouths full, someone loudly arguing about protein ratios like it was foreign policy.

Mydei reached for a roll.

Phainon reached for the same one.

Their hands hovered, close enough that Mydei could feel warmth.

Phainon didn’t pull back. He looked at Mydei’s fingers instead.

“You can take it,” he said.

“I was being polite.”

“Hm.”

Phainon took the roll anyway, broke it cleanly in half, and placed one piece onto Mydei’s plate with careful precision, like he was setting something important down.

“Then let’s not waste the effort.”

Mydei stared at the bread.

Then at him.

Phainon met his eyes briefly, something gentle and unreadable passing between them, before turning back to his own plate.

Mydei looked down again, irrationally aware that Phainon had touched the bread first, split it with his hands, decided where the seam should go.

He hated that his brain went there.

He ate it anyway.

And then later that evening, after rehearsals and sponsor greetings blurred together into polite exhaustion, Mydei wandered out to the riverside terrace overlooking the Salzach.

The water moved steadily below, catching stray light and breaking it apart. The city felt quieter here—less obligation, more air.

Footsteps approached.

Phainon stopped beside him, close enough that their coats brushed when the wind shifted.

“Cold?” he asked.

“Comfortable.”

Phainon hummed, then shrugged out of his coat without ceremony and draped it over Mydei’s shoulders like this was the most obvious solution in the world. He leaned against the railing beside him, forearms resting there, posture loose and unguarded.

The coat was warm, and it smelled faintly of that perfume again, like the tail end of summer. Mydei tucked himself into it a little more than necessary, pretending it was just about the cold.

“You run warm,” Phainon added casually, eyes still on the river. “But your hands get cold first, like mine actually. I noticed earlier.”

Mydei’s throat tightened. “You notice a lot.”

“I like noticing,” Phainon said. “Especially you.”

The words landed gently.

They stood there, shoulder to shoulder, silence settling easily instead of demanding to be filled. The river moved. Somewhere behind them, people laughed. Music drifted faintly from a nearby event space.

Phainon shifted slightly, closer, his arm brushing Mydei’s.

“You’re good company,” he said after a moment. “You don’t fill space just to hear yourself talk, which admittedly I appreciate… a lot. It’s restful. Thank you for that.”

Mydei laughed under his breath, something soft and surprised escaping him before he could stop it.

Phainon smiled at the sound, pleased, like he’d been hoping for that exact reaction.

After that, conversations found them more often.

Not all at once. Just pieces slipping in where there was space.

A comment exchanged while waiting for coffee. A shared glance across a crowded room. Phainon offering his scarf without asking. Mydei remembering how Phainon took his tea.

Small things.

Easy things.

Like the one time they end up sitting on the edge of the equipment crates while staff reset the floor, feet dangling, nowhere urgent to be.

Phainon leaned back on his palms, looking up at the ceiling like it was a sky he’d seen before.

“I miss Lisbon,” he said once. “Not the tourist bits. There’s this street near the river that smells like coffee and salt at the same time. Every morning. You hear delivery carts before you hear people talking.”

Mydei glanced over. Phainon’s eyes were unfocused, somewhere else entirely.

“Naples does that too,” Phainon went on. “Loud in a way that doesn’t overwhelm me. You can tell what time it is by the noise. Istanbul’s quieter in the mornings than you’d expect. Prague creaks when it rains.”

“You remember cities by sound,” Mydei said.

Phainon smiled, pleased. “And fabric. And food. Maps never helped me much.”

He tugged absently at the sleeve of his white shirt, rolling the cuff up just a bit. “I like white when I travel. Keeps things simple. Also—” He hesitated, then shrugged. “My mother used to braid her hair every morning. Same color. This reminds me of that.”

He said it lightly, like it was an obvious thing, then added, “Aglaea hates it.”

Mydei raised an eyebrow. “The color?”

“The combinations,” Phainon corrected. “She staged an intervention after I paired yellow and purple.”

There was a beat.

“She took photos.”

Mydei snorted before laughing, the sound slipping out of him before he could catch it. He covered his mouth instinctively, but Phainon was already looking at him, eyes shining like he’d just been handed something rare.

“There it is,” Phainon said. “I was hoping I’d get that again.”

Mydei dropped his hand, feeling awfully warm again. “You’re… surprisingly bad at dressing yourself.”

“Unfortunate,” Phainon agreed. “I excel elsewhere.”

This time Mydei didn’t bother to hide his snort.

Other times he talked about his hobbies.

Phainon held up a small metal component, turning it over in his hands. “This kind of thing,” he said, tapping it once, “outlasts people. Whole dynasties. You hold it and it’s like—” He searched for the word, fingers slowing. “You’re borrowing time. You don’t own it, you just keep it safe for a bit.”

His hands were cool to the touch.

Mydei leaned closer without noticing he’d moved.

“And you don’t get nervous?” he asked.

Phainon glanced up. Caught him there. “Only if I stop respecting it.”

They stayed like that—talking, pausing, letting silence breathe—until the prep call came through and the world nudged them back into motion.

It was pleasant.

By the end of the prep block, Mydei stopped questioning how often they ended up like this—side by side, mid-conversation, like it was the most natural thing in the world.

Phainon never seemed surprised when it happened.

If anything, he looked quietly delighted.

Mydei realized, with a warmth that settled low and steady in his chest, that he was too.

Technically, none of this was mandatory for Mydei.

Technically, his sponsors never *said* mandatory. They preferred phrases like *strongly encouraged* and *strategic visibility opportunity*, delivered via cheerful emails full of exclamation points and attachments that read like legal threats wearing party hats.

Technically, his team respected his autonomy.

In practice, they had perfected the art of herding him with the mastery of people who had done this for years and no longer had patience for resistance.

Which was how he found himself being bodily escorted into a car and then into another Messezentrum at nine in the morning, hair doing something rebellious and unsanctioned, clutching a paper cup of semi-melted slush like it was life support.

“Drink faster,” Hephaestion told him, steering him by the shoulder. “You’re vibrating at an unacceptable frequency and while I don’t give that much of a shit—unless you’re dead or dying—Perdikkas will have my head.”

“I’m fine,” Mydei said, sounding like a liar.

They’d missed the *main* showcase—the headline Red Bull biomechanics spectacle that involved wingsuits, prototype exoskeletons, and at least one thing that definitely violated aviation laws—because Ptolemy had gotten into an argument with a logistics coordinator over badge access and somehow lost twenty minutes to a heated discussion about data transparency.

So instead, they’d been funneled into the secondary exhibitions: still prestigious, still packed, just slightly less explosive and closer to their location.

The hall they entered was anything but small.

The Messezentrum had been converted into something between a cathedral and a control room. Steel rafters arched overhead, rigged with lights and massive LED screens looping slow-motion footage of athletes mid-motion—runners, climbers, drivers, skaters—every muscle annotated in glowing overlays. The air buzzed with layered sound: machines whirring, projectors humming, multilingual chatter ricocheting off metal and glass.

It smelled like cold air dragged in from outside, damp coats, ozone from electronics, and the unmistakable sharp sweetness of energy drinks.

Banners hung from the upper levels like war flags.

Mydei felt it settle into his bones—that familiar, pre-event hum.

Ptolemy, naturally, had already abandoned them.

Mydei spotted him near a motion-analysis platform, fully gone, eyes lit up like someone had just unlocked a forbidden archive. He was scribbling notes at a speed that suggested the presenter had personally spoken to his soul. Every so often he'd nod hard enough that a nearby Austrian coach unconsciously matched the motion, like they'd synced frequencies.

"Gone," Hephaestion said fondly. "We've lost him."

"He's happy," Mydei replied.

"That's how you know he's unreachable."

They moved deeper into the hall. Interns clustered around displays like pilgrims, whispering reverently at lines of code and skeletal overlays. Somewhere, a drone demo buzzed overhead, earning both applause and a frantic shout from staff.

Mydei was aware—painfully—of the glances. The recognition. The murmurs he absolutely understood and categorically ignored.

He'd perfected that skill years ago.

Or so he thought.

A VR technician waved him over, bright-eyed and earnest, her badge swinging as she spoke in a friendly lilt.

“Would you like to try die schwierigste Stufe—oh! Sorry. The hardest mode?”

Sleep-deprived and on autopilot, Mydei nodded.

“Sure.”

The simulator unfortunately, did not survive Mydei in “ja, natürlich” mode.

The simulator, unfortunately, couldn’t handle Mydei in “Ja, natürlich” mode.

He breezed through the course—reflexes clean, reaction times crisp—and the machine, overwhelmed by whatever impossible numbers he triggered, crashed in a dramatic cascade of errors that lit up the entire interface.

The engineer stared at the dead screen.

Her shoulders slumped.

The silence around them thickened.

She exhaled, slow and hollow, like someone watching months of work evaporate in real time.

That did it.

He dropped the pretense and apologized to her in fluent German for three minutes straight because there was no universe in which he could look at her without a guilt conscious and pretend not to understand.

He explained what he’d done, what he’d felt, reassured her it was impressive tech, genuinely impressive, and that the fault was absolutely his.

He did not stop for those three solid minutes.

Her face transformed.

Radiant. Victorious. Like he'd just handed her the secret to cold fusion.

Which meant she now knew he spoke German.

Which meant the VR lab knew.

Which meant staff knew.

Which meant press would know by lunch.

His carefully curated defense strategy—*Sorry, I don't speak German*—lay in ruins.

Hephaestion clapped him on the back with the solemn gravity of a man delivering condolences.

"Day one," he murmured, "and you've already sacrificed a tactical advantage."

Mydei sighed, long and resigned, as Ptolemy finally resurfaced, eyes gleaming.

"Did you see the force-distribution model?" Ptolemy asked, oblivious. "It's revolutionary."

Mydei glanced at the dead simulator. Then at his team. Then back at the roaring hall around them.

"…I'm going to need another slush."

And without discussion, someone was already handing him one.

By the time Mydei glanced back, Ptolemy had vanished.

He spotted him a moment later near the motion-capture stage, already seated, notebook open, pen moving like the presenter had personally issued a challenge. Numbers, angles, quick diagrams filled the page in tidy lines.

Beside him sat Phainon.

Phainon sat beside him, posture upright, legs long and still, wearing the kind of neutral expression that made strangers instinctively swerve around him in a five-meter radius. Whether it was the resting bitch face, the height, or the aura of “could kill you with a paperclip,” no one was sure. Regardless, their accidental isolation meant Ptolemy finally had enough elbow room to take notes unhindered.

They shared the silence easily.

Phainon leaned a fraction closer every so often, eyes drifting toward the notebook with open curiosity. Ptolemy noticed and tilted the page without looking, muscle memory kicking in like he’d done this a thousand times before. Phainon followed along, brow creasing as if the equations were personal.

Once, he murmured, “That angle changes torque distribution, right?”

Ptolemy beamed. “Exactly,” he whispered back, thrilled. He flipped the page and launched into a quiet explanation, hands moving as he talked, pen tapping out emphasis.

Phainon listened with complete focus, nodding slowly, filing everything away. The presenter might as well have been background noise.

Mydei watched from a distance, a strange lightness settling in his chest as he felt oddly relieved.

They got along. That was good to know.

The rest of the morning unfolded in motion.

Engineers guided Mydei from station to station. Gloves embedded with grip sensors. Visor prototypes flashing telemetry across his field of vision. Motion-capture dots mapped across his limbs as cameras traced every movement with clinical devotion.

He smiled for photos. Posed when asked. Stepped carefully through clusters of interns vibrating with excitement. Each time someone flinched as he passed too close to fragile equipment, Hephaestion drifted in like a protective satellite, redirecting traffic with practiced charm.

By midday, the hall buzzed louder. Demonstrations wrapped. Data streamed. Applause rippled through sections as breakthroughs earned their moments.

Ptolemy resurfaced at last, eyes bright, cheeks flushed, already mid-sentence about joint-load optimization. Phainon followed, hands tucked in his pockets, expression relaxed in a way Mydei recognized instantly.

Hephaestion watched them approach, then glanced at Mydei. “Huh.”

“What?” Mydei asked.

Hephaestion nodded toward them. “Your friend just got adopted.”

Phainon stopped beside Mydei, attention shifting smoothly. “Your team runs like a machine,” he said, mildly impressed. “Everyone covers each other.”

Ptolemy hummed agreement. “Supportive. Good snacks.”

Perdikkas appeared with impeccable timing from God knows where, clapping his hands once. “Speaking of efficiency,” he announced brightly, “Sports Medicine Day starts tomorrow. Departure at six.”

Mydei’s spine straightened on instinct.

Ptolemy winced in sympathy. Hephaestion suppressed a cough. Phainon glanced at Mydei, eyes filled with something that looked suspiciously like pity.

“I’ll bring coffee,” Phainon offered, already committing to it like a promise.

Mydei exhaled, the tension easing despite himself.

Around them, the Messezentrum surged with movement and noise, a world in constant forward motion.

And somehow, right in the middle of it, his people stayed close.

Perdikkas arrived fully awake and fully dressed like the concept of dawn had personally endorsed him.

“Up,” he said, already inside the room, tossing Mydei’s jacket onto the bed.

Mydei, hair committing several crimes against gravity and face still buried in the pillow, emitted a sound that suggested existential despair.

Perdikkas answered with a firm pat to the shoulder—reassuring, unstoppable. He had never lost a war to sleep and did not intend to start now.

Ten minutes later, Day Two began with Mydei being escorted through the hotel lobby like a disgruntled orange cat in human form, wrapped in his jacket, clutching a croissant he vaguely remembered someone pressing into his hands for survival reasons.

Peucesta filmed the whole thing for exactly twelve seconds before Hephaestion knocked the phone out of his hand.

“Archive it,” Hephaestion said. “For later emotional leverage.”

SPORTS MEDICINE & RECOVERY

The venue looked less like a medical facility and more like a wellness temple funded by someone who believed LEDs solved most problems.

They’d skipped the main arena again, deliberately this time. The flagship stage would be crawling with cameras, commentators, and carefully edited recovery montages. This hall sat just off the central axis—still elite, still sponsored to hell and back, but quieter. More hands-on. More fun.

The entire space glowed in icy blues and soft purples. Cryo pods stood along one wall like sleek, upright sarcophagi. Massage tables filled the center, each staffed by physiotherapists who radiated calm competence. Compression boots hung overhead like metallic vines. Somewhere near the middle, a DJ mixed low electropop beats designed to slow heart rates and smooth breathing.

More sport sponsorship logos appeared everywhere—etched into glass, pulsing softly along the floor, projected in slow motion across curved walls. Other sponsors flanked them: recovery tech startups, biomechanics labs, nutrition brands with names that sounded like chemical compounds.

Perdikkas—humbly nicknamed The Grouch—was euphoric for once.

He moved through the space like he belonged there, greeting physiotherapists as if they were old colleagues rather than people he'd emailed three times with bullet-pointed enthusiasm. He tested massage guns with reverence, rotating them in his hands, studying the specs like a car enthusiast inspecting an engine block.

"This one has adjustable percussion depth," he said, impressed. "That amazing."

Hephaestion—because yes if Mydei had to go so did he—nodded gravely. "Obviously."

Meanwhile, Mydei submitted himself to the schedule.

Scans. Sensors. Balance assessments. A full-body recovery analysis that hummed politely around him, light bands tracing muscle groups with unnerving precision. The machine beeped softly as if pleased.

The technician—a Hungarians woman with kind eyes and a tablet held close—studied the data, lips pursed in focus.

"Your recovery efficiency is unusually high," she said at last. "Athletes with your training load typically require longer rest cycles."

She glanced at him again, reassessing.

Mydei shrugged, tired but polite. “I sleep. I eat. I stretch.”

Perdikkas straightened like he’d just been personally praised.

Hephaestion crossed his arms, expression smug in a way only long-term caretakers could manage.

Peucesta looked up from his phone, eyebrows lifting despite himself. “Huh.”

Years of forced hydration. Mandatory cooldowns. Relentless monitoring. Someone always reminding him to stop being stupid and sit down.

Apparently, it paid off.

Then the booth asserted itself.

A representative in a neon windbreaker—vibrating with brand loyalty—ushered them forward with ceremony. He gestured toward a large, glowing tub.

“The world’s first electrolyte-infused ice bath with customizable aurora lighting.”

The water shimmered in layered greens and blues, shifting gently like the Northern Lights had decided to pivot careers.

Mydei stared. “Does the lighting… do something?”

“It enhances mental atmosphere,” the rep said smoothly. “Which enhances recovery.”

Perdikkas nodded with conviction. “Of course it does.”

Ptolemy hovered near the edge, fascinated. “The placebo effect alone probably boosts compliance.”

Coincidentally, Phainon had just appeared, drifting through the hall with Castorice. She gestured toward a recovery booth, clearly mid-rant about tendon protocols, and he listened, nodding at the right moments.

Then his gaze shifted.

He slowed without meaning to.

Castorice followed the line of sight, spotted Mydei and his entourage clustered around the glowing ice bath, and smiled. Mydei saw her steering herself away and was able to hear, *"I'll catch you later."*

Phainon didn't argue.

He approached with unhurried steps, a small paper bag appearing from his jacket pocket as if it had always been there. He stopped a polite distance away, hands slipping back into his pockets after he offered it.

"Promised," he said simply.

Inside were sweets—neat, carefully chosen ones that Mydei especially enjoyed.

He stood a step back, watching the team with quiet interest, taking in the easy bickering and practiced care.

When Mydei glanced over, Phainon caught his eye and chuckled.

"You look less miserable today," he said.

Mydei huffed. "I've been bribed with advanced technology."

Phainon nodded, serious. "That explains it."

Then, inevitably, Mydei was kidnapped.

The compression-suit demonstration happened fast. One moment he was standing near Phainon, the next he was being politely but firmly guided

onto a raised platform by two medics who moved with the confidence of people who had done this to Olympians before.

The suit sealed around him with a soft pneumatic hiss.

It tightened. Released. Tightened again.

Mydei stared down at himself, encased in sleek black fabric, limbs compressed just enough to be deeply undignified.

“I look like a vacuum-sealed dumpling,” he observed.

Perdikkas beamed. The expression carried the unmistakable pride of someone watching their child wear formal attire for the first time. “Perfect compression ratio,” he said. “Beautiful engineering.”

Peucesta had already circled the platform, phone raised. He took photos from the front. The side. Slightly above. A short video followed. Then another, closer this time.

A notification chimed.

Mydei didn’t bother asking who the video went to. The answer would only hurt him.

Hephaestion leaned in, hands on hips. “Hold still. You’re ruining the symmetry.”

“I cannot breathe,” Mydei replied calmly.

“That means it’s working.”

At the next station, another medic beckoned them over to a glass display holding a sensor no larger than a fingernail.

“This tracks muscle fatigue, hydration shifts, micro-tremors, and stress markers,” she explained, tapping the screen as data scrolled by.

Mydei squinted. “Does it track mental damage?”

She considered him carefully, nodded with professional gravity, and said, “That feature is in development.”

Perdikkas hummed, intrigued. “Put us down for updates.”

The afternoon blurred into rotations. Talks on injury prevention delivered by surgeons who spoke like mechanics. Nutrition panels that devolved into friendly arguments between Peucesta and a dietician over protein absorption rates. A hydration monitor that chirped sharply whenever someone forgot to drink.

It chirped at Mydei three times in under ten minutes.

Perdikkas ordered two on the spot. He tried to add a third for Mydei until Hephaestion gently took his tablet away.

“Let him live a little,” Hephaestion said.

“My definition of living includes electrolytes,” Perdikkas replied.

By the time the hall began dimming and staff started resetting booths, the team regrouped near the exit, arms full of brochures, samples, and one suspiciously heavy tote bag no one remembered picking up.

On the way out, Mydei paused at a display table and reached for a protein bar labeled:

EXPERIMENTAL FORMULA—LIMITED TESTING

Hephaestion stopped. “You’re really doing that.”

“It says experimental,” Mydei said, thoughtful. “I want to know what kind.”

He took a bite.

Chewed.

Paused.

“…This is concerningly good.”

Peucesta leaned over his shoulder. “Give me that.”

Perdikkas made a note to find the manufacturer.

As they spilled back into the cool evening air, the exhaustion settled in—the good kind. Muscles tired. Heads full. Everyone talking at once, trading impressions, teasing each other, planning dinner without actually agreeing on anything.

The day had been gentle in its own way. Tests, tech, mild humiliation, collective nonsense.

A victory, really.

All in all it was a pretty good day.

Day Three arrived wrapped in clear morning light, sunlight spilling through the mountains. Mydei woke up before his alarm, which immediately put him on edge—until he realized he didn’t feel dread crawling up his spine.

Curiosity, instead. Actual curiosity.

He mentioned, casually over breakfast, that the aquatic exhibitions sounded interesting.

The team froze.

Perdikkas narrowed his eyes, suspicious of traps.

Hephaestion checked his phone, as if expecting a prank confirmation.

Peucesta glanced up from his coffee, eyebrow lifting half a millimeter.

Ten seconds later, they were already dressed and moving. No coercion required. A miracle.

Everyone showed up—well, everyone except Ptolemy, who avoids going out whenever possible, and Leonnius, who apparently considered sleeping in a competitive sport.

As per usual, they skipped the main event for the side.

The aquatic complex sat just outside Salzburg, all glass and steel, its massive windows framing the mountains like someone had deliberately composed the view for dramatic effect. Inside, sound carried softly—water slapping against tile, laughter echoing upward, the springy thoomp of divers hitting boards before vanishing into blue.

It felt alive in a different way than the other venues.

Jet boards rested along the far pool, sleek and predatory, water beading off their surfaces. A drone zipped beneath the waterline in one lane, projecting skeletal overlays onto a screen as swimmers powered forward. Another area buzzed around a demonstration labeled **WATER PROPULSION SPRINT**, complete with industrial fans and instructors who spoke with the confidence of people who trusted physics too much.

Mydei drifted through it all slowly, hands tucked into his jacket, eyes tracking movement. The divers held his attention the longest—pairs rising together, splitting apart midair, bodies cutting clean arcs before piercing the water in perfect unison.

His team experienced the venue differently.

Which is to say, they acted like an underfunded daycare.

Hephaestion had acquired a stopwatch within five minutes. Where it came from remained a mystery. He leaned over the railing, timing swimmers he did not know, offering crisp commentary under his breath.

“Late entry.”

“Good drive off the wall.”

“Interesting kick pattern.”

The swimmers who hadn’t asked for feedback nodded politely, deeply confused.

Perdikkas stationed himself at the pool edge, hands clasped behind his back, delivering an impromptu lecture on global drowning statistics to anyone within earshot. His gestures grew increasingly dramatic, slicing the air toward the deep end like he was warding it off personally.

And then there was Peucesta.

Mydei spotted him last.

Peucesta sat cross-legged at the edge of the leisure pool, utterly relaxed, sleeves rolled up. In his hands: a remote control. Beneath the water, a miniature submarine zipped back and forth with deliberate movements, its tiny lights blinking cheerfully.

Mydei stopped walking.

Stared.

The submarine performed a slow turn. Paused. Then tilted upward.

Peucesta lifted one hand in greeting.

The submarine lifted too.

Mydei stood there for a full two minutes, brain trying to file this under something reasonable. Eventually, he decided peace was found through acceptance and turned away.

At least everyone was enjoying themselves.

The jet-board challenge arrived with unnecessary fanfare. Staff gathered spectators, music swelled, someone used the phrase “controlled ecstasy” with a straight face.

Mydei scanned the group, smiled faintly, and said, “Peucesta.”

“What,” Peucesta replied, already stepping forward.

Mydei volunteered him with zero warning.

He mounted the board like muscle memory took over. Found his balance in seconds. The water surged beneath him, lifting him cleanly as he glided forward, posture loose, expression bored.

He turned. Then turned again.

He even struck a pose.

Hephaestion lost it.

The madness escalated when the Water Propulsion Sprint fired up at the far end of the pool.

Industrial fans roared to life. A competitor launched forward across the water in an explosion of spray so aggressive it looked less like a sport and more like someone getting forcibly reintroduced to the concept of gravity.

The crowd went feral.

Hephaestion leaned over the railing, stopwatch already in hand.

Perdikkas shouted something about mandatory safety regulations that absolutely no one heard.

Peucesta steered his submarine closer, clearly invested.

Mydei stayed where he was, arms resting on the railing, watching the water ripple and reform under the lights. Sun filtered through the glass panels, mountains steady and indifferent in the background, like they’d seen far stranger things than humans strapping themselves to fans.

He breathed in. Let it out.

Noise. Motion. People he liked arguing about nothing important. Water slapping against tile. Laughter echoing off steel beams.

It was ridiculously loud, but he wouldn’t trade it for the world.

DAY 4—AIR & AERODYNAMICS DAY

If Day Three shimmered with noise and splash, Day Four arrived on a quieter wavelength.

The aerodynamics research center sat beside a wide hangar tucked into the outskirts, its silhouette cutting clean lines against the pale morning sky. Cold air rolled through the open space, carrying the low, steady hum of engines undergoing calibration somewhere out of sight.

Inside, everything gleamed. Polished floors. Glass partitions etched with airflow diagrams. Red-and-white hazard tape marking paths like visual footnotes. The faint metallic scent lingered everywhere, sadly.

This was a thinking person’s venue.

A group of engineers led them toward a compact wind tunnel designed for wingsuit and aerial stability training. The machine looked deceptively calm—no roaring jets or anything.

Mydei stepped in first, fitted into a lightweight suit. When the airflow activated, it pressed against him evenly, a steady force rather than a shove. His posture adjusted on instinct, arms shifting, weight redistributing, body responding quickly. The engineers murmured among themselves, trading small nods.

Peucesta filmed the entire thing from two angles. *Again*.

He circled slowly, focused, adjusting framing with the seriousness of a documentarian capturing a once-in-a-lifetime migration. The footage already had a cinematic air to it—soft light, controlled motion, Mydei suspended like a study in balance.

Somewhere, a group chat notification chimed in anticipation.

Leonnius, meanwhile, had vanished.

Not physically—he was still very much present—but socially, he'd been absorbed into the engineering ecosystem like a particle caught in a current. He stood shoulder-to-shoulder with three researchers, mid-conversation, hands moving as he talked through airflow variance and micro-adjustments.

"Right, because the moment you introduce asymmetry, you're compensating with muscle memory instead of physics," Leonnius said, tapping the tablet one of the engineers had handed him.

The engineer grinned. "Exactly. Most athletes don't articulate that part."

"Well," Leonnius replied easily, "they feel it instead, no?"

Another engineer slid him a chair. Someone else pulled up a simulation. Leonnius leaned in, fully in his element like the others have been before.

Mydei caught sight of him through the glass and smiled to himself.

Outside the center, the grounds buzzed with activity. A drone-racing exhibition threaded its way through a narrow obstacle course near the hangar, LEDs streaking through the air in sharp bursts of color. The buzzing was rapid and electric, drawing clusters of spectators who flinched and laughed as drones zipped past their heads.

Across Austria, the rest of the team was scattered—Perdikkas had apparently discovered a museum with "excellent informational plaques," Hephaestion had sent photos from a café claiming to have the best pastries in the country, and someone had tagged Peucesta in a blurry street shot captioned *he escaped again*.

Phainon wasn't around.

A passing staff member mentioned the skating teams had an early ice session across town.

Mydei perked up slightly.

Then returned his attention to the wind.

By the time they regrouped near the hangar, the day had settled into a pleasant rhythm—conversations overlapping, engineers trading jokes with athletes, staff weaving through with clipboards and ease. A director approached them with a relaxed smile, like she was offering a suggestion rather than an invitation.

“We’re filming a light flight segment this afternoon,” she said. “Hangar shots. Controlled rigs. Nothing intense. Anyone interested?”

Mydei turned, already forming a polite response.

“Yes,” Leonnius said immediately.

One of the engineers raised a hand, half-volunteering out of enthusiasm.

Mydei blinked once.

The director smiled wider.

And just like that, Day Four—quiet, technical, almost meditative—lifted gently off the ground and angled itself straight toward mayhem.

The hotel blinds always leaked light in irritatingly precise stripes—thin gold cuts across the ceiling like someone had taken a ruler to the sun. Mydei sat directly beneath them, laptop balanced on his knees, absorbing the glow with quiet resignation.

He was half-dressed for Day Five’s motorsport event. Driving suit tied around his waist. Undershirt wrinkled where he’d been tugging at it without noticing. Hair freshly blow dried. He looked awake only in the legal sense—heartbeat present, eyes open, soul buffering.

Today was supposed to be *his* day.

Motorsport day.

Social media had spent the past week acting like it was a foregone conclusion: Spielberg, Red Bull Ring, cinematic shots of asphalt and history. Because of course that's what you expect the major sponsors to do.

Except the schedule drop had landed last night and immediately detonated expectations.

No iconic circuit.

No production nightmare.

No pilgrimage to motorsport holy ground.

It was karting.

Partner karting, to be exact.

A compact track set up on the edge of a local motorsport academy, filmed with drones and branded so aggressively that even the tire barriers looked like they'd signed endorsement deals. The kind of event designed to trend precisely because it *wasn't* what anyone predicted.

The internet was baffled.

Mydei wasn't.

This entire week had been a masterclass in plausible deniability—scenic activities marketed as competitions, participation framed as accessibility, famous faces sprinkled in just enough to guarantee circulation. Karting fit perfectly. Low barrier. High energy. Clean visuals. Everyone thinks they could do it. That was the point.

Normally, mornings like this were for quiet recalibration—stretching, mental laps, letting the nerves settle into something usable. Instead, he'd made the mistake of sitting down "for a second" with his laptop and letting the lounge soften him.

It wasn't even early. The hotel had fully woken up around him. Boots squeaked down the hall. Suitcases rattled. Somewhere below, ceramic cups

clinked in the breakfast buffet like a warning bell he was choosing to ignore. Cold crept in through the window frames no matter how aggressively the heater worked, that crisp Alpine chill that always reminded him of layovers and long-haul fatigue.

He was halfway through an email when the lounge door snapped open hard enough to protest.

Cipher entered like weather.

She didn’t just walk in—she *arrived*, already mid-thought, already scanning the room like she’d been disappointed before she even opened the door.

Her eyes landed on Mydei.

She frowned.

“Get up,” she said, pointing at him like he’d been left in the wrong place. “You look like a depressed businessman. We’re going to the place.”

Mydei blinked. Once. Slowly.

“I have meetings—”

“No you don’t.” She crossed the room in three strides and grabbed his sleeve, tugging just enough to make it clear she had several escalation levels available. “Get in the taxi.”

The worst part was that he stood without much resistance.

He could’ve argued. He could’ve insisted on routine, preparation, *exhaustion*. He could’ve asked where they were even going when he was meant to be racing later.

He didn’t.

Cipher smirked, satisfied.

Maybe it was the lingering fog of the morning. Maybe it was the half-finished coffee cooling on the table. Or maybe it was the simple truth that Cipher didn’t drag people out of hotel lounges unless she had a reason—and Winter Sports rehearsals were scheduled for tomorrow.

Figure skating included.

He only fully connected the dots once the taxi pulled away and the city shifted around them. Streets narrowed. Signage aged. Snowbanks melted into dull gray slush under weak sunlight. This wasn’t postcard Salzburg—it was the functional version. The one that worked.

By the time they arrived, his breath fogged white in the air.

The rink looked like something the government had built decades ago and forgotten to apologize for. Concrete box. Metal overhang. Doors scuffed and stubborn. Not glamorous or impressive in anyway. Exactly right.

The best training facilities always looked a little unloved.

Inside, the temperature dropped another few degrees. Cold slid under his collar, snapping his focus into place. Ice rinks carried a particular quiet—even when occupied, there was always something restrained humming beneath the noise.

Cipher shoved her hands into her jacket pockets and nodded toward the rink.

“Try not to scream,” she said casually.

Mydei frowned, confused, but stepped forward anyway.

The sound hit first.

Blades carving ice. Long, confident strokes. A rhythm built from repetition and control.

He entered the viewing area—

—and stopped.

Two skaters were already on the ice.

One was Castorice,

moving like she’d been born there.

The other, a few meters behind her—

Phainon.

The realization crept up on him instead of striking.

At first it was just familiarity tugging at the back of his brain—the way one skater cut their edges a little deeper into the ice, the timing between pushes that felt conversational rather than counted. Muscle memory recognizing muscle memory. A language his body had spoken fluently once, even if his life had veered elsewhere.

Then the shape resolved.

Phainon leaned into a curve, knee soft, weight stacked cleanly over the blade, and something in Mydei’s chest went unhelpfully quiet.

He forgot to blink.

Castorice laughed as she skated past him, the sound carrying even over the hum of the rink. She tapped her toe pick lightly against the ice—once, twice—an impatient little rhythm that made Phainon glance over his shoulder. He lifted a brow in response, exaggeratedly slow, like he was daring her to start without him.

She did.

Castorice pushed off first, carving a sharp outside edge that snapped into a wide arc. Phainon followed a heartbeat later, accelerating to match her speed with long, easy strokes that ate up the ice. They didn’t rush to sync;

they let the gap breathe, reading each other through peripheral vision and instinct.

Mydei's fingers curled against the railing.

…Not for the program then. This was the two of them skating because they enjoyed it, and because the ice was there and empty and theirs for the next forty minutes.

They crossed paths at center ice, shoulders close enough that Mydei felt it like a phantom brush. Castorice dipped low into a spread eagle, arms flaring out as she let the edge sing. Phainon mirrored the curve on the opposite side, not matching her exactly—complementing it. His free arm extended back, palm open, offering shape and space.

She took it without looking.

Their hands met mid-glide, fingers slotting together with the ease of habit leads to. Castorice used the connection to pivot into a traveling turn sequence, a clean bracket into a counter that snapped her shoulders around just enough to send her skirt flaring. Phainon adjusted instantly, switching edges to stabilize their shared center, his knee bend deepening to absorb the shift.

Mydei swallowed.

He knew how unforgiving those turns could be if your timing slipped by even half a beat. Watching Phainon support them without making it obvious hit something deep and unfairly tender.

They rotated together into a death spiral entry, Castorice dropping low while Phainon anchored, blade locked, core engaged in a way that made Mydei's brain short-circuit for entirely unprofessional reasons. Castorice laughed again as she skimmed the ice, one hand tracing a lazy arc along the surface, the other gripping his.

She popped back up smoothly, using his arm as leverage, and instead of resetting properly, she bumped her shoulder into his chest.

“Too slow,” she said, loud enough for him to hear.

Phainon smiled—actual teeth this time—and flicked snow at her with a sharp stop. “You rushed it.”

“Because you hesitate.”

This side of Castorice was unfamiliar to Mydei, and he couldn’t help but pay closer attention.

“Because it’s fun.”

They took off again before the argument could finish, energy crackling between them. Castorice launched into a toe-assisted hop she hadn’t planned, landing slightly off-axis. Phainon caught the deviation immediately, sliding closer, his hand firm at her waist as he redirected her momentum into a sweeping curve that turned the mistake into choreography.

Mydei exhaled.

God.

They were good.

Not just technically—though that was there in spades—but *together*. Comfortable enough to tease, confident enough to recover, attentive in the way that came from years of shared ice and shared trust. Unlike the performances Mydei had watched before, this wasn’t about the scoring—they were just showing each other what they could still do.

And Phainon—

Mydei leaned forward, elbows on the railing now, fully compromised.

Up close, he could see everything. The way Phainon’s shoulders stayed relaxed even through complex footwork. The precision of his rocker transitions. The faint hitch in his breath after a longer sequence, managed quietly, professionally, like he didn’t want anyone to notice.

Mydei noticed anyway.

He catalogued it without meaning to. The controlled power in his thighs as he pushed through a lutz entry he aborted at the last second, choosing a step-out instead. The quick grin he flashed Castorice when she applauded playfully. The way he shook out his arms, loosening tension, then immediately re-centered.

This was the man who had lived in Mydei's head for years as highlight reels and interviews and whispered what-ifs.

This was better.

Cipher appeared beside him again, leaning casually against the glass like she hadn't just detonated his emotional stability for the day.

"Still breathing?" she asked.

"Barely," Mydei said, helpless.

She hummed, pleased. "Thought so."

Castorice skated backward toward Phainon, counting softly under her breath—"Five, six—no, again"—and he followed, matching her tempo, nodding along. They tried a lift entry next. Castorice jumped early, laughing when it went crooked. Phainon staggered half a step, caught her anyway, and set her down with a theatrical bow.

She curtsied deeply in response.

Someone near the boards clapped as a rink tech laughed. The sound guy adjusted his levels and pretended not to be filming even harder.

Mydei pressed his knuckles to his mouth, smiling so wide his cheeks hurt.

It was impossible not to be happy watching someone who'd poured themselves into their work simply delight in what they could do.

Phainon skated past the boards, closer this time.

For a split second, his eyes flicked up.

They met.

Phainon’s expression shifted—surprise first, then recognition, then something happy that made Mydei’s stomach drop through the floor.

He lifted two fingers in a small wave, sheepish and bright all at once.

Mydei waved back like an idiot.

Cipher snorted quietly. “Oh, you’re doomed.”

Mydei didn’t even try to deny it.

He stood there in the cold, chest tight with something like awe, watching the man who had inspired him glide across the ice—carefree, alive—under harsh lights, corporate banners, and a playlist held together by nothing but the moment itself.

They held the opening pose just long enough for it to matter.

Castorice leaned slightly into Phainon’s side, one knee bent, blade resting on a shallow edge. Phainon stood tall beside her, chin lifted, one arm angled just enough to frame her line without touching. It was the kind of tableau that made people pause mid-sip of coffee. Somewhere behind the boards, an internet let out an appreciative whistle.

Then the music kicked in again—bright, brassy, upbeat in a way that felt almost cheeky, like a parade marching straight through the rink.

They launched.

Phainon accelerated first, powerful but unhurried, strokes long. Castorice snapped into motion beside him half a beat later, matching speed with a smile that flickered across her face before she smoothed it into performance polish. They hit their toe loops together—tight, snappy, the takeoffs nearly mirrored.

The landings rang out in crisp unison.

Cipher tilted her head, pleased. “That one’s for the cameras,” she murmured. “Short, flashy, clean. Sponsors eat it up.”

Mydei barely heard her.

Phainon carved a deep bracket, knee flexing smoothly, weight stacked so perfectly it made Mydei’s fingers itch like he wanted to trace the edge on slow-motion replay. Castorice answered with a counter turn, her blade whispering as it bit into the ice. They crossed paths in a tight choctaw, shoulders almost brushing, lines splitting and rejoining like call-and-response.

“They’re insane,” Mydei muttered, half in awe, half in disbelief. “That spacing—”

Cipher didn’t even look at him. “Don’t be a buzzkill, they know exactly where the other one is. Relax, little prince~”

Castorice broke away with three quick running steps, pushing hard into speed. Phainon followed, timing his approach like he was counting her breath. When he reached her, his hand found her hip—confident, economical—and she rose smoothly into the lift, weight settling cleanly into his center.

She extended upward, one arm slicing toward the lights. Phainon rotated beneath her steadily, edge carving a wide arc that sent a fan of ice glittering behind them.

Mydei made a quiet, weak noise.

Cipher smirked. “Yeah. That.”

They came out of the lift in perfect sync, sliding into backward crossoversl. The lighting caught the fine tracery of skate marks etched into the ice, turning the surface into a pale mosaic beneath their blades.

Castorice unfolded into a spiral, leg lifting effortlessly behind her, back arched in a line that made even the bored tech by the Zamboni door straighten. Phainon stayed close. One hand hovered near her back, a silent support.

The assisted layback spin bloomed next. Castorice dropped into it with theatrical ease, hair flaring as she rotated. Phainon guided the axis with subtle shifts of his own edge, circling her like he was drawing the spin tighter through will alone.

“Showoffs,” Cipher said fondly.

The tempo surged again.

They launched into diagonal footwork, blades digging deeper now, edges singing. Phainon’s turns grew broader, more grounded; Castorice matched him with sharper accents, their styles complementing. It felt like watching two musicians riff off the same melody, pushing and pulling without ever losing the beat.

They finished the sequence in a dramatic slide stop, snow spraying high and bright under the lights.

The finale came fast.

Castorice sprinted toward Phainon. He glided backward to meet her, posture relaxed, eyes locked on her center. In one fluid motion he scooped her up, pressing her overhead as if she weighed nothing at all. Her body stretched into a long horizontal line, arm reaching outward, fingers splayed like she was flying.

They traced a wide circle across the rink, her silhouette blurring slightly with speed, before rotating together in a half-turn that felt almost cinematic.

The music cut.

Silence fell.

Phainon lowered her carefully, their blades guiding them into a mirrored final pose—knees bent, free legs extended, hands grazing the ice. For a heartbeat, everything stilled.

Then Phainon looked up again.

Mydei was already there, leaning over the boards like gravity had a personal vendetta against him.

Their eyes met once more.

Phainon's expression changed and he gave the faintest smile.

Mydei forgot how cold it was. Forgot the cameras. Forgot that Cipher was absolutely watching him fall apart in real time.

Castorice pushed off into a relaxed lap, skating loose and unguarded now, shaking out her arms like she'd just finished a particularly satisfying workout. Cipher tracked her for a second, then brightened with a dangerous sort of inspiration.

"Oh, this is perfect," she said, already shrugging off her coat. "I'm stealing a lap before your skater boy notices."

Mydei shot her a look. "He's not—"

Cipher grinned wickedly. "Mm-hm."

And somewhere out on the ice, Phainon laughed—soft, unguarded—before skating over, still flushed from motion, still glowing with that easy joy and contentment Mydei had loved for years from afar.

Seeing it up close was ruining him.

He wouldn't have traded it for anything.

Cipher patted Mydei's shoulder with theatrical sympathy.

Then she skated off.

Just—gone. Vanished into the rink with a Cheshire smile and zero remorse.

Mydei stood there for half a second longer than necessary, brain buffering, heart trying to exit his ribcage through sheer enthusiasm. He told himself to breathe. He told himself he was a professional adult with sponsors and schedules and a public image.

And then Phainon stepped off the ice.

Up close, the details hit harder. The faint frost clinging to his sleeves. The flush at his cheekbones from exertion. The way he moved with that quiet, understated grace even while doing something as mundane as snapping skate guards into place.

Mydei's pulse did something deeply unprofessional.

Phainon brushed ice shavings from his gloves, tugged them off with his teeth, and finally looked up.

Direct eye contact.

Mydei became acutely aware of the exact temperature of the rink, the exact texture of the rubber mat beneath his shoes, and the fact that his hands were doing absolutely nothing useful.

Phainon's gaze flicked briefly to where Cipher was lacing up like she'd just been handed permission to commit a felony. "She moves fast," he said mildly.

"She moves like consequences are a myth," Mydei replied. "It's her defining philosophy."

That earned him a sound from Phainon—soft, warm, unmistakably amused. It loosened something in Mydei's chest he hadn't realized was wound tight.

Phainon shifted his weight, leaning back against the boards with easy familiarity. "I've been meaning to ask," he said, tone casual in a way that suggested he actually meant it. "How did you meet her? And Castorice?"

Mydei blinked. “Oh. Uh.”

He tugged at the cuff of his sleeve, more out of habit than nerves. “A few years ago, I sponsored a charity training camp where they had been volunteering. Grassroots program. Travel stipends, gear, ice time—the boring but important stuff.”

Phainon listened intently.

“My family was supposed to co-sponsor,” Mydei continued. “It… ended up being me running most of it. Castorice showed up first. She looked me in the eye and said my playlist had… an interesting sense of timing.”

Phainon’s mouth curved. “She says that with affection.”

“I learned that later,” Mydei said. “Cipher thanked me three days after the camp ended. She looked equal parts worn out and quietly proud. That was enough for us to click. She really cares about the kids, even if she doesn’t exactly seem the type.”

Phainon hummed thoughtfully. “And you stayed in touch.”

“Yeah.” Mydei shrugged, smiling despite himself. “Castorice checks in. Cipher appears when she wants something or thinks I’m spiraling.”

“Efficient system,” Phainon said.

There was a pause.

Phainon glanced back toward the ice, where Castorice was circling slowly, stretching her shoulders while Cipher narrated something with her hands. Then he looked at Mydei again, expression softer now.

“Your skating earlier,” Mydei said, words spilling out before he could reassemble his dignity, “was—”

He stopped. Restarted. Failed again.

“It was incredible,” he finished, a little breathless. “The timing in your step sequence, the way you adjusted your axis in the lift—sorry, I’m not— I mean, I know that sounds—”

He cut himself off, cheeks warming. Fantastic. Truly stellar behavior.

Phainon, however, looked… surprised. Not uncomfortable. More so caught off guard.

“…Thank you. That means a lot,” he said after a beat.

Mydei, emboldened by exactly one (1) successful sentence, kept going. “And your breathing—near the end, after the diagonal footwork. You shifted your cadence slightly before the final lift. I noticed because—”

Because I 100% know your habits better than my own warmups.

…What the hell is he doing.

He stopped himself just in time.

Phainon’s eyes shifted, something contemplating passing through them. “It’s an old injury,” he said. “Managed. I’m good.”

Mydei nodded, the concern still lingering in his gaze. “Alright.”

Castorice coasted up nearby, resting her hands on the boards. Cipher followed, breathless and triumphant.

“I did a lap,” Cipher announced. “It was spiritually enriching.”

Castorice sighed. “She nearly took out a camera operator.”

Phainon glanced between them, then back to Mydei. “They’re working on something,” he said, reading the situation instantly. “If you’d like—”

He hesitated, just a fraction. Then smiled, small and sincere.

“Would you walk with me?”

Mydei answered far too quickly. “Yeah.”

…And that’s how they ended up in the hallway together, falling into pace like they’d done it a hundred times.

Mydei stole a glance at Phainon and felt that familiar, dangerous warmth bloom again—admiration, fondness, something he didn’t quite have the words for yet. He let himself enjoy it, just this once.

Walking beside him felt nice.

Mydei checked the time on the glowing wall display as they rounded the corner. Tomorrow’s schedule scrolled past in neat blocks—practice ice, media windows, tech checks—everything moving along like the rink never truly slept.

He glanced sideways. “Tomorrow’s your performance, right?”

“Yes,” Phainon said.

“I’m planning to go.”

The words came out easy.

Phainon slowed a fraction, then actually stopped walking. “…Why?”

It slipped out before he could catch it—blunt, unguarded, more curious than suspicious. The moment it landed, he visibly realized how it sounded. His shoulders shifted, a subtle recalibration, eyes flicking away like he was already rewinding the sentence in his head.

“I didn’t mean—” he started, then paused, searching for the right phrasing. Social grace was clearly not his strongest muscle, though Mydei wasn’t one to talk. “You don’t have to.”

Mydei blinked, genuinely puzzled. “I want to.”

Phainon looked at him again.

Mydei shrugged lightly, hands in his pockets. “It feels right to see it for myself,” he said, thinking it through out loud. “If something matters to you that much, I want to know what it looks like when you’re inside it. When it’s yours.”

He meant it exactly as he said. Practical. Plain. This was how he dealt with most of his friends—who, for the record, had very little patience. Somehow, they usually appreciated it. Mostly

Phainon, unfortunately, was not built to receive statements like that without consequences.

His fingers stilled where they’d been fidgeting with his sleeve. The corner of his mouth twitched, like he’d been caught off balance by a sudden change in terrain.

Mydei noticed. Immediately worried. “Did I say that weird?”

Phainon swallowed, then shook his head. “No. I—” He exhaled, quiet. “No. It’s… nice.”

The word came out a little rougher than intended.

The exit doors loomed ahead, night pressed up against the glass in reflections of city lights and passing cars.

Mydei’s phone buzzed again at his hip.

Once. Twice. Three times in rapid succession.

He sighed. “That’ll be Peucesta,” he said with deep resignation. “If I don’t answer soon, he’ll assume I’ve been kidnapped or joined a cult.”

Phainon’s lips curved.

Mydei slowed, then stopped, turning slightly toward him.

“Before I go,” he said, meeting Phainon’s eyes, “I should probably say this clearly.”

Phainon straightened without meaning to.

“I’d like to see you again,” Mydei said, warnest. “No pressure. I just— I enjoy talking to you.”

That was it, really. He just didn’t want to make him feel awkward by mistake.

Phainon’s reaction was immediate but small—eyes widening just a touch, breath catching like he’d misjudged the timing of a step. He didn’t freeze so much as hesitate, recalibrating again, as if the floor had shifted by a centimeter and he needed to adjust his balance.

“Oh,” he said.

Then, gentler, “I’d like that too.”

Relief warmed Mydei’s chest. He smiled. “Good.”

He stepped back, giving Phainon space before the moment could grow heavy. “Goodnight, Phainon.”

“Goodnight,” Phainon echoed.

Mydei turned, already pulling out his phone as it lit up with frantic messages. He didn’t look back—didn’t see Phainon standing there a moment longer than necessary, one hand half-lifted like he’d meant to say something else and lost the timing.

He didn’t see the faint flush rising along Phainon’s neck, or the way he stood there smiling at nothing, long after the doors had swung shut.

And lastly, he didn’t notice Phainon shift just slightly, a small, almost imperceptible straightening, like he was bracing himself for tomorrow’s performance—and somehow, Mydei felt a little flutter, knowing he’d be there to see it.

Chapter End Notes

Well I barely know my ice skating terms and stuff so plz don’t jump me guys (I think I dragged the skating sequence too much? Sorry abt that 😭),thanks for reading!! Again if there are any mistakes or if y'all have any constructive criticism, feel free to tell me :)

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!